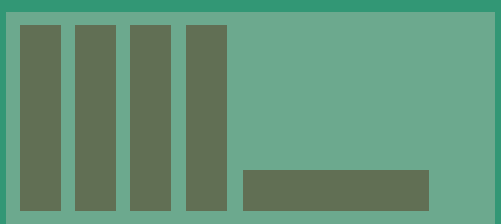
The Politic

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BETTING ON BOOKS

CAN THE INDIE BOOKSTORE REVIVAL LAST?



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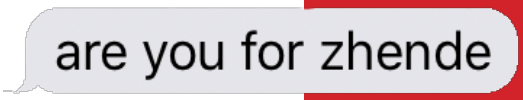
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NOT SUBTLE, VERY ASIAN



A Facebook Group Offers Community, Comfort, and Even Love

BY **KATHY MIN**

"THIS IS QUITE A BIT of a long shot but this group is at nearly a million members so I figured why not," wrote Allison Yao, a 20-year-old student at the University of California, Berkeley, in a December 2018 post in the Facebook group Subtle Asian Traits.

Three months earlier, Subtle Asian Traits (SAT) was a mostly unknown meme group with a few thousand members, described as an "inside joke" by its founders, most of whom are 18 or younger. By the time of Allison's post, the group's membership boasted an impressive global reach, largely comprised of 20-something Asians across the English-speaking world—Asian Americans, Asian Canadians, Asian Australians, and more.

Allison posted a photo of herself and an unknown Asian man. She had taken the photo two and a half years earlier, on a choir trip to Switzerland.

"Who are you?" Allison asked in the post. "You were the first Asian… that my friends and I had seen in a long while…[I don't know] if you're out there, but SAT, do your thing."

Within a day, the mystery man from Switzerland had already identified himself in the comments section and in a private message to Allison. Although he had not initially joined Subtle Asian Traits, his friends had seen the post and prompted him to reach out.

Allison said they had a friendly conversation "piecing together the bits of the puzzle," figuring out how and why they "ended up in the same place at the same time." But while reconnecting with a stranger from her past was enjoyable, she saw her post as an experiment.

"My main purpose was to see what the power of community would hold, in the strength of such a large group, especially in a group that is such common space for Asians now," Allison told me.

Other "missed connections" posts popped up in Subtle Asian Traits, with Asians searching for elementary-school classmates who moved away and long-lost comrades from online computer games like Maplestory.

Facebook groups dedicated to sharing humorous memes are the latest trend in internet culture. But, as Allison's post showed, Subtle Asian Traits has evolved beyond its comedic origins into a million-member global community, shrinking degrees of separation between the members of the Asian diaspora.



IN SEPTEMBER 2018, inspired by another meme page called Subtle Private School Traits, a group of 17- and 18-year-old Chinese Australians from Melbourne decided to form Subtle Asian Traits, a closed Facebook group. Memes span topics ranging from love of boba tea to bilingual humor to the habits of immigrant parents.

"It wasn't really planned out or anything," 17-year-old Darren Qiang, one of the group's founders, told me. Darren and the other founders knew one another from the Chinese language school they attended on weekends.

"It was a very impulsive decision," Darren recalled. "We were having a chat overnight and our conversation started out as, 'Hey, it would be cool to start a Subtle Asian Traits.' Initially, we thought it was just as a joke, just for some fun."

In a matter of weeks, Subtle Asian Traits had captivated droves of Asian millennials across the Western world, catapulting its founders into the spotlights of high-profile publications like *The New York Times* and generating offers to purchase the group.

"Before we reached 10K followers, the group progressed fairly slowly," Darren said. "I think it took us three weeks to hit 10K. But as soon as we hit 10K, we would be getting a guaranteed 25K a day."

(In fact, one in three of my friends on Facebook have joined Subtle Asian Traits.)

After several months of membership in the group, its memes seem commonplace to me. But I remember the joy I felt upon first discovering Subtle Asian Traits, when, in October 2018, a Chinese American friend messaged me "some fun Asian memes." I remember keeling over with laughter at the oddly specific brand of humor. The memes she sent me would only make sense to those who, like me, are fluent in Chinglish.

Chinglish, a portmanteau of Chinese and English, is the dominant language in my family. When I speak Chinese with my parents, who immigrated to the U.S. in the '90s, I often resort to English when a word's Chinese equivalent eludes me. My parents are also active Chinglish speakers; they say they've been away from China for so long that they sprinkle English in their sentences to supplant the Chinese phrases they can no longer remember. Chinglish, a product of the Chinese diaspora, aptly showcases the multilingualism of many immigrant families. Before last fall, I'd never seen it in meme format.

"男人 <=> 难人," reads the first

Subtle Asian Traits meme my friend sent me. The first word, 男人 (phonetically pronounced *nanren*), means "men," and has the same pronunciation as 难人, which roughly translates to "difficult person." Therefore, the meme concludes, there are "no coincidences in the Chinese Language."

"Are you for zhende?" reads the second meme my friend sent me. *Zhende* is the phonetic spelling of the Chinese phrase for "true" (真的), but as an English speaker from a Chinese household, nothing about this Chinglish version of "Are you for real?" is confusing.

In the first few days after my discovery, I spent copious amounts of time on my phone perusing the page, delighted by the humor of shared experiences, like my grandparents' insistence that I drink warm water and my family's reverent love of Costco—experiences I once believed were peculiar oddities of my family and upbringing.

Aside from cultural quirks, Subtle Asian Traits is replete with humorous and relatable recountings of life for Asians in the diaspora. For example, one meme pokes lighthearted fun at the lack of Asian representation in the *Harry Potter* book series, joking that the only options for Asians at a "Harry Potter themed event" are to dress as Cho Chang, who is of Chinese descent, or Nagini, an evil snake that author J.K. Rowling recently revealed to be Indonesian.

SUBTLE ASIAN TRAITS' popularity gave me a sense of affirmation. For the first time in my life, I felt like I had found a space where I felt completely at ease with my identity as a second-generation Asian immigrant. In Subtle Asian Traits, I felt no need to explain myself: swaths of members had experienced some permutation of my Spotify playlist titled "Mandobops," my love of Chinese home cooking despite only being able to cook stir-fried tomato and egg (the most iconic Chinese dish among my culinarily-challenged generation), my trepidation while visiting relatives in China who jokingly derided my Mandarin, my childhood years spent playing Pokémon with my brothers and passing notes to friends in weekend Chinese school classes.



I did not have to explain why daily encounters with racial ignorance were frustrating, nor did I have to explain why something was racially ignorant in the first place. For memes from cultural contexts I was less familiar with, such as jokes in Vietnamese or Korean, I still felt appreciative of the humor. There was a level of shared understanding in this group, made of Asians from every corner of the English-speaking world, from Asian enclaves that hosted third- and fourth-generation Asian Americans, to conservative, all-white suburbs like my hometown, to continents beyond my preconceived notion of the Asian diaspora.

Anne Gu, 18, another Subtle Asian Traits co-founder from Melbourne, told me, "I feel like [in] our culture, there's this sort of Asian and Western cultural identity, and how we have to juggle both is something that brings us all together... regardless of where you are, whether it's America, Australia, New Zealand, all around the world."

"It's nice to see Asians connecting globally, not just in Melbourne or Australia. It's gone to a bigger level, which is amazing, because it's like one big family all around the world," Anne said. "We only intended it for a joke, relatable memes, and now it's something bigger than that. It allows

For the first time in my life, I felt like I had found a space where I felt completely at ease with my identity as a second-generation Asian immigrant.

people to feel proud of who they are and their identity and culture that they come from, which is really good because it all connects and bonds us together."

An offshoot page called Subtle Curry Traits predominantly features content for South Asians in Western societies. According to founder Noel Aruliah, a student at Monash University in Melbourne, Subtle Curry Traits was, like Subtle Asian Traits, intended as a joke. However, with the growing popularity of Subtle Curry Traits, Noel feels that it has become something more meaningful.

"This has brought all these traits and cultural things together, which is really nice to see. There's something that a lot of people can relate to," Noel explained. For example, memes in Subtle Curry Traits about strict parenting have broad cross-cultural appeal.

The strong sense of community in groups like Subtle Asian Traits and Subtle Curry Traits has inspired members to address community issues, such as mental health. As of January 2019, the offshoot page Subtle Asian Mental Health Support has over 12,000 members.

"**THIS IS NOT** an orthodox way of getting to know someone."

Kevin Pu, a recent graduate of Northwestern University and a prospective pediatric oncologist, laughed with a certain self-awareness as he said this. After all, he met his girlfriend, Sophia Sun, a recent graduate of Pomona College who works at Microsoft, through Subtle Asian Dating, one of the most popular offshoot pages of Subtle Asian Traits.

Subtle Asian Dating has been described as the modern Asian millennial's version of their parents' marriage markets, which are popular in Asia for matchmaking. In Subtle Asian Dating, comprised of over 300,000 members as of January 2019, friends "auction off" their single friends with posts comprised of flattering photos and suggestive, emoji-laden pros and cons lists. Both Sophia and Kevin were auctioned off by their friends on Subtle Asian Dating.

"So I'm scrolling through the page, and I'm like, *ugh*, all these boys with their whatever 'six-six-six,' six pack, six figure, whatever, whatever, investment banking, I'm not interested in this at all," Sophia scoffed in a joint conference call with Kevin and me. "And then I come upon his profile—"

"Makes no money, isn't six feet, and has, like, no six pack," Kevin interjected, smiling.

"It wasn't emojis exploding all over the place, because that freaks me out a little bit. It was really funny and sincere," Sophia recalled. "So I was like, I'll just message him. Maybe he's a receptive stranger, maybe he's not."

Given the complicated dynamics of dating for Asians in Western societies—from fetishization to being seen as completely undateable—it is perhaps unsurprising that Subtle Asian Dating is so popular.

Sophia said she felt a certain comfort in all-Asian spaces and described Subtle Asian Dating as "endearing."

"I just feel like the meme culture among first, second-gen Asian Americans—even just the way I type and talk to my Asian friends is very different than how I would talk to my white friends," Sophia observed.

Kevin described a sense of "safety and security" in Subtle Asian Dating.

"We don't run the risk of being discriminated against for our interests or our foods or whatever else, and we don't run the risk of people assuming things about us because our family's from a certain country," he added.

When I initially reached out to Kevin and Sophia, they emphasized that they did not want to be simply "ten seconds of 'cuteness'" on Subtle Asian Dating, but instead "part of a more long-term change to how Asians...approach dating and interactions with new people."

Kevin is critical of "rigid dating expectations" that permeate Subtle Asian Dating, such as the valorization of conventional beauty standards and lucrative careers. To Kevin, because Subtle Asian Dating is such a safe space, the ability to "be open" to transcending such limiting expectations is a "unique luxury" of the group.

FOR ALL THE WAYS Subtle Asian Traits and its affinity groups have

"We only intended it for a joke, relatable memes, and now it's something bigger than that. It allows people to feel proud of who they are."

brought together Asians across the Western world, it has not come without criticism.

"In many ways, Subtle Asian Traits can reproduce existing inequalities," said May Lin, a Ph.D. candidate at the University of Southern California who studies race, social movements, and Asian American youth.

Allison's search for an unknown Asian man in Switzerland, for example, garnered toxic, misogynistic responses.

Members of the Subtle Asian Traits sent her "tasteless" comments encouraging her to date the mystery man, despite Allison posting that she was in a "happy and healthy relationship."

"What I had most qualms with were the sheer amount of 'friendzone' accusations," Allison said. "I received a lot of accusational comments with slut-shaming themes, like, 'What are you doing? If you already have a boyfriend, why are you putting so much effort to searching for this long-lost guy across the globe?' 'What are you going to do now, friendzone the poor dude?'"

Because the "friendzone" is not a concept specific to Asian communities, Allison believed the comments to be a "reflection of society that is extremely heteronormative and expects any interaction between a male human being and a female human being to have romantic implications."

"What's even more interesting is that I don't identify as heterosexual, but I know for a fact that if I posted a post like this and the other person had been a woman instead, none of these comments would have been there," said Allison.

"There definitely seems to be a privileging of heteronormative and patriarchal norms within the group," Lin noted.

"I do think the degree of pressure put on Asian women to cater to the needs of Asian males, to be in relationships with them, is also immense," Allison said. "In addition to posts I've seen on Subtle Asian Traits, as well as Subtle Asian Dating, there's a lot of criticism against Asian women for these phenomena."

Outside of the gendered dynamics that Allison experienced, many users have called attention to the dominance of East Asian and Southeast Asian memes, with South Asian content relatively sidelined.

One candid post on Subtle Asian Traits by a Pakistani American user criticizes the notion that South Asians don't count as "Asian."

"[A] lot of us have noticed general racism towards south asians [*sic*] in this group or feel uncomfortable posting here and don't engage here," the post reads. It garnered nearly 8,000 likes and reacts.

However, Darren says the issue isn't gatekeeping.

"The biggest problem is not that we're not accepting South Asian content," Darren said. "It's just that that content isn't coming in to be approved in the first place."

This may have to do with the creation of Subtle Curry Traits as an alternative space for South Asian content.

Noel of Subtle Curry Traits also does not see Subtle Asian Traits as explicitly exclusionary, noting that many admins of Subtle Curry Traits are actually friends with Subtle Asian Traits admins. But he admits that the "Asian" in Subtle Asian Traits often does not seem to extend to South Asians.

"You can say the target of Subtle Asian Traits is definitely more of East Asian and Southeast Asian countries," Noel said.

Despite being a space for a cohort of Asians who often experience racialization in their countries of residence, Subtle Asian Traits seems to shy away from any sort of politicization. According to a Facebook message from Darren, the admins have "decided collectively to stray away from any political agendas or raise topics that are too political." This perspective was evident in my conversation with Darren and Anne, who stressed that the group was more about shared culture and cultural pride.

But Lin pointed out that visible representations of Asians in Western culture can themselves be political, albeit less explicitly so.

"Because Asian cultures are perceived as grounds for racial alienation, practicing pride in culture might be a political act in and of itself," Lin said.

Both Darren and Anne emphasized themes of Asian "empowerment," but refrained from describing empowerment as a response to inequality.

"I wouldn't say Australia is necessarily racist to Asian people. As a country, we're fairly good because our country is made up of immigrants from all over the world," Anne said. "Not many [Asian Australians] get mistreated; it's all fairly balanced and respectful."

In the United States, the term "Asian American" is inherently political, arising out of the Civil Rights Movement and pan-Asian movements decrying racism against various Asian American groups. And in Australia, contrary to Anne's anecdotal observations, some studies show that Asian Australians still face pervasive race-based discrimination, from anti-Asian vandalism to housing discrimination.

Yet, as Lin notes, Asian American groups often opt for outward political neutrality. Although Subtle Asian Traits is certainly unprecedented in terms of scale, it is not the first Western Asian online community; Asian American message boards and Asian American YouTube culture, for example, predate Subtle Asian Traits by nearly two decades. However, Lin sees little promise in these kinds of Asian American and Western Asian forums becoming political or activist spaces.

"Identities need to be connected to political meaning, and folks need spaces to learn concretely how to engage in politics," Lin said. "I don't see Subtle Asian Traits doing that explicit political work, which is why I think there's little promise for this being a space for activism."

Of course, Subtle Asian Traits is far from a perfect community. But it is mind-boggling to me that my cohort of peers—Asian millennials and Gen-Z's of the Anglosphere—stand at the center of an unprecedented internet phenomenon. Almost unthinkably, this page, the brainchild of Australian teens younger than me, has reunited long-lost childhood friends, sparked romantic relationships, and formed support systems.

I will always remember the advice Mary Lui, the head of Yale's Timothy Dwight College, imparted to her students during the final lecture of her course on Asian American history. More than anything, Asian Americans should continue to create spaces for themselves, she reminded us. It is a sentiment I often reflect on as I explore my own Asian American identity and spaces for Asian Americans like Subtle Asian Traits.

Despite Subtle Asian Traits' shortcomings, I still hold on to the hope that, here, unlike anywhere else, when our fingers are on the keys, we can shape the kind of community we want.



Out of Pocket

How Michigan Teachers Make Do

BY **MCKINSEY CROZIER**

SEVERAL HIGHWAYS INTERSECT in the charming, albeit unremarkable manufacturing town of Cadillac, Michigan, which is nestled in the Manistee National Forest on the shores of two lakes and one river. The latitude of the northern Lower Peninsula provides a rare sweet spot for deciduous trees to coexist with the pines, and, in true Midwestern fashion, the people are perhaps *too* friendly. With all the bias of a lifelong resident, I can say that I have been to few places with more beauty and charm.

But my hometown faces many of the challenges plaguing rural Michigan as a whole: Wexford County Prosecutor Jason Elmore (R) cited early in 2018 that drug arrests are among the highest in the state per capita. Cadillac Area Public Schools—from which I graduated in 2018—reported a free or reduced lunch rate of 58 percent, which, according to the National Center for Education Statistics, defines the area as a mid-range poverty district. The relationship between education and poverty is apparent in Cadillac, where school facilities have failed to meet student needs for decades, and local property taxes and donations do not sufficiently supplement state per-pupil funding.

On May 15, 2018, the local Board of Education approved the first phase of construction on a 65.5 million-dollar bond to improve school facilities, many of which are cramped, outdated, and unsafe. In one high school chemistry classroom, students struggle in near-freezing indoor temperatures; in classrooms with leaky ceilings, overhead tiles commonly crumble and fall. Many of these spaces have needed repairs for years, even decades. The bond was a scaled-back version of a 2017 proposal that had been rejected by voters. Some of the upgrades in the 2018 bond had been proposed in a bond failed by voters in 1996, approximately ten years before current Cadillac seniors were of school age.

Lisa Kassuba, a fifth-grade teacher at Mackinaw Trail Middle School, has worked in this school district for 28 years. "I feel like I was born to be a teacher," Kassuba told me.

But Marsha McGuire, a kindergarten teacher at Franklin Elementary School, one of Cadillac's four elementary schools, emphasized that although she finds her job rewarding, being a teacher also comes with a tremendous responsibility to personally fund supplies, professional development, and even students' basic necessities. "In no other profession would we expect someone to put so much of their own money and resources into their job without being compensated [for it]," McGuire told me.

School budgets in Cadillac allot only small stipends of 100 to 200 dollars for classroom supplies, and these stipends rarely cover full expenses. McGuire said she has spent an "obscene" amount of her own funds supplying her classroom.

Sheila Bosman, a career educator who taught for Cadillac Area Public Schools before moving to teach kindergarten at a local private school, described experiences similar to McGuire's. "As a kindergarten teacher, one finds that our meager annual classroom budget [at Cadillac's public schools] just barely covers consumables such as crayons, markers, colored paper, glue, and paint," she said. "I never had any extra money to replace broken items like puzzles and blocks."

Teachers have learned to be cost-savvy, especially when required to fund classroom improvements themselves. "Teachers are hoarders, creative, frugal, recyclers, reusers, and bargain hunters," Bosman said.

Teachers have not seen any significant raise in classroom stipends for decades. Meanwhile, inflation rates have averaged approximately three percent per year, and teacher pay in Michigan has eroded over the past two decades. Adjusted for inflation, Michigan teachers are paid 11.5 percent less than they were 20 years ago, and Michigan is one of 12 states that have cut school funding by more than seven percent per student over the past decade. Michigan allots Cadillac 7,500 dollars per pupil—the lowest amount the state allots to any district. Cadillac's allocation is 26 percent lower than Michigan's recommended minimum per-pupil spending of 9,590 dollars, which does not account for sharp spending increases recommended for at-risk and non-native English-speaking students.

Michigan's per-pupil funding method was proposed in 1994 under the administration of John Engler (R), who was governor from 1993 to 2001. The policy was

originally intended to close the resource gap created under Michigan's previous school funding structure, which funded schools solely through local property taxes. But rather than increasing education spending in poorer areas, Michigan implemented a tiered system that granted more resources to wealthy districts accustomed to higher education budgets. Despite the supposedly equal per-pupil allocations, inequality persisted.

Coupled with Michigan's statewide fiscal challenges and declining property values, unequal education funding exacerbated the problems faced by poor school districts. Michigan also shifted funding to privately-run charters, favoring deregulatory practices and school choice. These policies, supported by advocates like current U.S. Secretary of Education Betsy DeVos, contributed to inequality in education resources and poor oversight of charter school performance. They funneled wealthy, white students out of public schools and created a de facto segregation policy.

The result? Although Michigan's per-pupil spending was once near the median of its Midwestern counterparts', a 2016 study from the National Education Policy Center ranked it at the bottom among Midwestern states. According to a 2016 report by the Education Trust-Midwest, Michigan's public education has been rapidly decreasing in quality over the past decade. While this disproportionately hurts low-income students of color, the report notes, "Michigan is witnessing systemic decline across the K-12 spectrum." Students are suffering—"white, black, brown, higher-income, low-income—it doesn't matter who they are or where they live."

Michigan has taken an increasingly deregulated approach to education, placing the well-being of its 1.5 million public school students in the hands of corporations by investing in for-profit charters at much higher rates than the rest of the nation. According to *The New York Times*, while for-profit charters account for just 16 percent of charter schools nationwide, they comprise 80 percent of charter schools in Michigan. Michigan now has the most for-profit charters in the country. And perhaps as a result, Michigan was ranked dead last in student proficiency improvements in a 2017 Brookings Institution analysis. Michigan lawmakers have allowed children to become vehicles for profit.

DESPITE STRUGGLING TO STOCK their classrooms due to inadequate education funding, some Michigan teachers use their personal income to meet students' basic needs. Bosman, the kindergarten teacher, recalled recycling her own children's items, such as clothing and toys, and purchasing clothing for students.

"When your children outgrow something or no longer play with certain toys, you find yourself taking them to school," she said. "I have even had to buy underwear, socks, boots, et cetera, to keep at school so there are extras when needed." Kassuba, the fifth-grade teacher at Mackinaw Trail, described pooling money with my mother, a school social worker, to fund a student's haircut.

I was no stranger to this phenomenon. When my mother worked at Kenwood Elementary School in Cadillac, she regularly provided students with basic necessities, paying out of pocket and using donations. She became well-known for carrying personal hygiene products for students in her purse, her car, and her office. When I was in elementary school, my mother sought donations for kids' snow pants and boots and, once, a new skateboard. She has anonymously funded thousands of dollars worth of Christmas gifts for Cadillac families.

Bosman ruminated: "Why do we spend our own money? One, we don't want any child to go without. Two, you can't ask for school supplies in a public school. You can ask for donations, but you aren't likely to get much. Three, you want the education setting to be safe, happy, and engaging."

A 2015 federal Department of Education survey found that nationwide, 94 percent of teachers had spent their own earnings on school supplies, and seven percent had spent over 1,000 dollars annually on school supplies. According to McGuire, teachers have always spent personal funds on classroom supplies, but it is "becoming more apparent because social media and the voices of teachers has helped tell the stories of what is really happening in the lives of teachers and their classrooms."

McGuire emphasized that effective teaching requires investment in creative teaching strategies, which can often be expensive. McGuire said, "If you want to have a hands-on, engaging curriculum for science—or even ELA or math—you need materials that your students can touch, manipulate, and explore. These items [have to] come with a new classroom. As a teacher, you are on your own to figure out how to acquire them."

Adding to teachers' expenses, quality education in the digital age requires access to technology. Psychological research cited by Edutopia, a popular education blog, portrays learning as a social and interactive process, one that cannot be reduced to bubble sheets and flash cards. Cadillac teachers favor methods like peer revision and small-group discussion, which aim to foster personal

"In no other profession would we expect someone to put so much of their own money and resources into their job without being compensated [for it]."

Nationwide, 94 percent of teachers had spent their own earnings on school supplies.

growth and a more detailed understanding of concepts. Many of these methods make use of technology like Google Suite and online forums.

My high school English class required us to submit weekly blog posts; in math, we used grant-funded Smart Boards and interactive videos; and for chemistry, teachers and students scrounged up money for sensors and graphing calculators while relying on excruciatingly slow computers for our labs. Even Kahoot, the popular review game, requires one technological device per student. McGuire explained: "The fact is, teaching in paper and pencil is just not a reality, and it's not [the] best teaching practice."

According to Benjamin Herold, a staff writer who covers education technology for *Education Week*, American public schools now house at least one computer for every five students. The same blog stated that the 2015-2016 school year was the first in which standardized tests for elementary- and middle-school students were administered more frequently online than with pencils and paper.

However, lack of access to technology remains an issue, especially in rural areas. Cadillac's 2018 bond aims to provide each high school student access to one device for classroom and home usage, but this goal is unlikely to be met for several years. Cadillac elected not to add one-to-one technology for K-8 level students due to research indicating potential harms of some screen technology for young children. Even so, the bond has no provision to grant elementary and middle schools important resources like computer labs or laptop carts.

In order to fund technology-focused opportunities for students, many teachers have turned to educational grants and professional connections. Two of my high school teachers kept grant-funded, mismatched sets of Google Chromebooks and iPads in their classrooms, but there still were not enough devices to meet student demand.

Teachers are also using technology to raise money for other needs. McGuire described using online crowdsourcing and fundraising platforms like Teachers Pay Teachers to share resources with other educators.

Kassuba recalled discovering how to attach an Amazon wish list to the Remind app. "I did it, and within an hour, parents had donated 50 dollars of the specialty paper I wanted for the kids to do a project. It was amazing because I couldn't go out and buy 50 dollars worth of paper. I could do it once, maybe, but I couldn't keep doing that kind of thing."

Social media allows teachers to engage with their professional networks, too. On Twitter, they share inspiration, ideas, professional development opportunities, and raise funds.

But fundraising on Twitter is haphazard and, ultimately, insufficient. The Department of Education's 2015 study also found that on average, teachers spend nearly 500 dollars a year on classroom spending. This amount does not account for the items teachers bring into their classrooms from home—hand-me-downs from their own children, for instance—or buy with donations. Still, it is double the 250 dollars in annual federal tax deductions that teachers can receive for personal spending in their classrooms.

Kassuba told me that classroom purchases occur throughout the year. "Every week when I buy groceries, there's something in my cart for my classroom. And I just do it because it's what I need to do my job. I don't really think about it—it's not always a lot at one time—but if I need it, I buy it," Kassuba explained.

"I even found myself rationalizing my spending by telling myself it was a gift to the students," Bosman reflected.

Having spent 14 years in the Cadillac Area Public School system, I was frequently caught between an instinct to criticize rural schools' lack of resources and a desire to laud their outstanding educators, who sacrifice their personal comforts to help kids who might otherwise go without. Cadillac teachers refuse to allow their students to become casualties of state budget battles.

This students-first mindset defined my experience as a student in Cadillac. My teachers saw financial investment in their classrooms as investments in *us*—their students.

My classmates have told me stories of teachers who transformed their experiences in K-12 education—teachers who invested in them. My chemistry teacher, for example, would stay several hours after the end of the school day to work with students.

"I know that many teachers feel that if we continue to supply classrooms using our own resources, things will never change," McGuire explained to me. "But I'm not that teacher that can just turn the other way and ignore the needs of my students."

By the end of a recent conversation with fellow Cadillac alumni about the people who made a difference in our high school lives, nearly every teacher was mentioned.

"OPEN ARMS"

BY **JORGE FAMILIAR AVALOS**

Colombia Faces the Venezuelan Migrant Crisis

THE LINE OF PEOPLE on the Simón Bolívar International Bridge, which connects the Venezuelan city of San Antonio del Táchira and the Colombian town of La Parada, only recedes when the bridge closes at night. Not far from the bridge, merchants mill about, trying to sell water bottles or luggage help to the recent arrivals. After crossing the bridge, the arrivals set off in search of basic necessities that seem to no longer exist back home.

More often than not, both the merchants and the arrivals are Venezuelans, pushed to Colombia in search of food and medicine by the dire economic situation on the other side.

As many as 30,000 Venezuelans cross the Simón Bolívar International Bridge every day into La Parada and move on to the border city of Cúcuta, whose population is 750,000. Most of the Venezuelans come only temporarily, but for months, as many as 3,000 a day have been making the trip with no intention of going back.

Venezuelans can cross into Colombia without a passport, instead presenting a Venezuelan identification card, which is easier to obtain. But thousands cannot meet that requirement and use secluded trails to enter Colombia undocumented, risking encounters with criminal groups.

Driven by desperation, the Venezuelan migrants are fleeing what has become the greatest humanitarian crisis in the Western Hemisphere. Recognizing the duress, Colombia has opened its doors, but with the flow of people unlikely to abate, concerns for the future are mounting. In pursuing a better life for their families, the migrants have strained Colombia's hospitals and schools.

Last June, the Colombian government announced that over one million Venezuelans had entered the country over the previous 15 months. The government has since estimated that another million will arrive by the end of 2019.

"The community is not ready for another mass of equal size," Father Francesco Bortignon, who runs a temporary migrant shelter on behalf of the Scalabrini missionaries in Cúcuta, told *The Politic* in a phone interview.

Despite the generosity that Colombia and neighboring countries have shown, there are escalating calls for regional actors and the larger international community to do more to support the migrants.

UNDERLYING THE VENEZUELAN exodus is the country's economic malaise. According to Dany Bahar, a David M. Rubenstein Fellow in Global Economy and Development at the Brookings Institution, the current downturn's origins go back to the presidency of Hugo Chávez, which began in 1999.

"His government did the opposite of everything you learn in Econ 101," Bahar said in a phone interview with *The Politic*. "It was an experiment in how to destroy an economy."

Bahar highlighted the Chávez administration's use of the largest oil boom in Venezuela's history to dramatically increase spending and finance a vast array of social programs. While these programs decreased poverty and boosted Chávez's popularity, the government overspent and severely indebted itself. Its failure to save any of the state-owned oil company's earnings or invest in other sectors set Venezuela up for failure.

Global oil prices crashed in 2014, during current Venezuelan President Nicolás Maduro's second year in office, and Venezuela soon became unable to service its debt. This made it impossible for the country to continue importing food, medicine, or other basic necessities like toilet paper and diapers.

While many countries export oil, Venezuela was the only one to spiral into such a severe crisis after the global price decline. "It is not fair to say that the crisis is due to the fall in the price of oil," Bahar argued.

The crisis also sparked the rampant hyperinflation and rising poverty rates that triggered the mass migration. The International Monetary Fund projected that inflation in Venezuela would exceed one million percent by the end of 2018, leaving Venezuela's currency, the bolívar, essentially worthless. Now, the IMF predicts the inflation rate will hit ten million percent by the end of this year.

"The poverty rate is among the

highest in Latin America, with 87 percent of households living under poverty," Bahar said. "Three-quarters of the Venezuelan population has lost up to 20 pounds of weight involuntarily," due to food shortages.

Amidst this economic carnage, Maduro has focused on centralizing power. In March 2017, the Supreme Tribunal of Justice dissolved the democratically-elected National Assembly, stripping the main source of opposition to Maduro of its legislative powers. In the months that followed, Maduro's government violently suppressed protests and began the process of withdrawing from the Organization of American States (OAS), a continental organization promoting regional cooperation and democracy, signaling his refusal to heed international criticism.

Demonstrations beginning in April 2017 were subjected to the attacks of the Bolivarian National Police, the Bolivarian National Guard, and pro-government gangs. Throughout the following summer, anyone who chose to join the protests risked being maimed, killed, or arrested: by September protests had become far less frequent. Between April and August 2017, 165 Venezuelans were killed and around 5,000 were arrested at anti-government demonstrations. Over the last year and a half, the violence has subsided, but inflation has skyrocketed, Maduro's authoritarian government has retained its power, and living conditions have deteriorated further. A new wave of protests, met with violent repression, began when National Assembly leader Juan Guaidó declared himself interim president in January 2019. Maduro remains president, but several countries, including the U.S. and Colombia, no longer recognize him.

"We are experiencing oppression. The Chavistas have control and remind us every day: 'We are in charge,'" said Javier Escalona, a former mechanic interviewed by Colombian newspaper *La Semana*. After his employer shut down its operations in Venezuela, Escalona began making routine trips across the border in search of money and supplies.

"You are killing us. We cannot do anything, but there is one who can. Think about it, Maduro, before it's too late. I want Maduro to listen to me: how many times have you gone to bed without eating?" cried María Helena Guzmán, a migrant interviewed by Colombian broadcaster *RCN* near the Simón Bolívar International Bridge last September.

"The only measure this government has to relieve internal pressure is to make people leave and transfer the problem to all the other countries of the region, which practically makes it one of the most immoral governments in history," OAS Secretary-General Luis Almagro told *The Politic*. "Almost no dictatorship on the continent has had such a detachment from the social problems of its country, as bad as they were, and there have been horrible dictatorships on our continent."

With no government response to chronic food and medicine shortages, Venezuela has become virtually unlivable for the majority of its citizens. For many, the decision to leave has become a choice between life and death—according to the United Nations, over three million Venezuelans have elected to leave since 2015.

SINCE LAST APRIL, Father Bortignon's migrant shelter in Cúcuta, the *Centro de Migraciones*, has been at or above capacity. The *Centro* was designed to hold 110 guests, but Bortignon has regularly been housing an average of 120 to 130 migrants—almost all of them Venezuelans—placing mattresses in the *Centro*'s hallways, its classrooms, and even its chapel to accommodate as many people as possible. Most migrants stay for only a few weeks at a time. In total, thousands have stayed at the *Centro*.

"We always try to get a few more people off of the street, because we would always end up with another 50 or 100 [migrants] on the street," said Bortignon. "We try to neither throw them out nor bother the neighbors."

The *Centro de Migraciones* was established 40 years ago, at a time when many Colombians were migrating to Venezuela due to guerrilla violence in their own country. It provided Colombians in Cúcuta with a place to stay before crossing into Venezuela. Between 1960 and the turn of the century, millions of Colombians arrived in Venezuela.

Personal ties between the two countries remain strong. Bortignon explained how many Venezuelans are able to turn to Colombian relatives or friends as an alternative to staying at the *Centro* or sleeping on the streets.

Katy Watson, the BBC's South America correspondent, told *The Politic*, "I've met people who are half Colombian and half Venezuelan, or people who are Colombian but now more Venezuelan. They're people who've got a connection and a shared history in both countries."

Besides housing, the nutritional, medicinal, and educational needs of the migrants arriving in Cúcuta present huge challenges. The *Centro* provides meals for hundreds of migrants on a daily basis at two community kitchens in the city and at a food stand closer to the Simón Bolívar International Bridge. But considering the malnutrition Venezuelans have suffered, the influx into Cúcuta has placed extreme pressure on the city.

The Colombian government has also granted the migrants full access to both Cúcuta's hospitals and public schools. Urgent health needs left unaddressed in Venezuela have resulted in long wait lines at hospitals. Overcrowded classrooms abound in schools. The *Centro* provides pre-kindergarten to high school education, serving around 4,000 migrant children, as well as mental health services for migrants.

There seems to be a genuine commitment to aiding the migrants from the highest levels of the Colombian government. Colombian President Iván Duque announced last November that the country devotes half a percent of its GDP to provide migrants access to a wide variety of social services.

Many private citizens are also doing all they can to help the Venezuelans. One woman Watson met, who owns a cafe in Cúcuta, gives migrants water and a place to sleep at night. The migrants, many of them penniless, leave

her notes expressing their gratitude. Responding to the migrants' needs, Bortignon has moved to expand the *Centro de Migraciones.* Within the next few months, the *Centro* will open a medical clinic and new housing and dining facilities that will allow it to feed another 400 people and shelter another 200.

But the organization's ability to offer aid depends on outside support and, as a result, remains fragile. The *Centro*'s existing aid programs and expansions have been possible only because of support from the World Food Programme, the United Nations High Commissioner for Refugees, and Cúcuta's municipal government. Local volunteers are essential to the *Centro*'s daily operations, as its staff consists only of three priests, two psychologists, two social workers, and a handful of permanent employees in the kitchen and security. Should any of the *Centro*'s sources of support fail to keep pace with the constant flow of migrants, efforts to provide humanitarian aid will suffer.

VERY FEW OF THE Venezuelans who arrive in Cúcuta stay there. Job opportunities are scarce in the area, and many migrants are headed elsewhere. While more than one million Venezuelans entered Colombia in 2018, hundreds of thousands moved on to other countries, especially Peru, Ecuador, Argentina, and Chile. Some left for other cities in Colombia, particularly Bogotá, the capital.

Last November, the first migrant tent city in Colombia's interior formed in Bogotá. Bortignon plans to open a second shelter in the capital due to the increasing number of migrants there.

Duque has expressed his commitment to what he calls an "open arms" policy, including legal entry and access to social services for migrants with standard Venezuelan identification cards.

Colombia's neighbors have not followed suit. In August, both Peru and Ecuador required that Venezuelans present passports upon entry, despite the difficulty of obtaining a passport in Venezuela.

According to Bahar, this growing heterogeneity of policy toward Venezuelan migrants across the region, which makes it harder for them to settle in countries like Peru and Ecuador, could be prevented if the migrants were officially recognized as refugees. The United Nations has not applied its definition of refugee status, which focuses on racial, social, and political persecution, to Venezuelan migrants.

But there is an alternative. "Latin America is the only region in the world that has expanded this definition to something much wider," Bahar said, referencing the 1984 Cartagena Declaration negotiated by ten Latin American countries and later endorsed by the OAS.

"The Declaration expands the definition and includes those who flee their country because of massive human rights violations or disruptions of public order," Bahar explained. "Venezuelans are fleeing Venezuela for a very clear reason: the country is going through the worst humanitarian crisis that the hemisphere has ever seen."

If the migrants were recognized as refugees, most countries in the region would be obliged to ease entry requirements under their treaty commitments.

In another worrisome development, there have been news reports of nascent xenophobic, anti-Venezuelan sentiments in Colombia and beyond. With huge numbers of migrants arriving in the country, concerns about disease and crime that new arrivals might bring have entered the public discourse.

In January 2017, then-Colombian Vice President Germán Vargas used a derogatory term for Venezuelans when he said "for nothing in the world, this is not for the *venecos*" at an opening event for new public housing units near the border. The incident sparked a media uproar and even drew condemnation from Maduro himself.

In the buildup to the October 2018 mayoral election in Lima, Peru's capital, candidate Ricardo Belmont repeatedly insinuated in his speeches that the Venezuelans would steal jobs from locals and hog social services. Belmont fought back against allegations of xenophobia, arguing that he was merely "defending the Peruvian." He ultimately won just 3.8 percent of the vote, but his rhetoric made a lasting impression.

Xenophobia has manifested itself in violent assaults and even mob attacks. In Bogotá, a rumor spread in late October that Venezuelan migrants living in the slums were kidnapping children, leading an angry crowd to pelt migrants' homes with rocks. Police eventually intervened, but not before a Venezuelan migrant who had been in the country for three months was badly beaten. He died in a Bogotá hospital.

Following several attacks on migrant tent cities in Brazil, the Brazilian government deployed the army to the border—not to deter to future migration, but to protect those who had already arrived.

Bortignon blames sensationalist news coverage of crimes committed by migrants for the rising xenophobic tide. He believes that people should focus on their common humanity with the migrants. "A human is a human, and errors or barbarities happen everywhere," he said.

INCREASINGLY, THE MIGRANTS who arrive in Cúcuta cannot afford to buy transportation out of the city. Instead, Bortignon attests that as many as 300 migrants walk out of Cúcuta daily. They embark on journeys of several thousand kilometers, to Bogotá and elsewhere, in search of better lives for their families.

Watson, who has reported from Cúcuta, has witnessed their desperation firsthand. "Everyone's got a terrible story," she said.

Often, parents leave their children behind in Venezuela, hoping to establish themselves abroad before returning to repeat the risky journey with their little ones. One distraught mother Watson met could hardly speak to her

because she had left her eight-month-old baby behind.

Another mother was eight months pregnant and traveling with her husband and her toddler. They had left without their two oldest children. The woman gave birth in Peru, but her baby passed away. The medical bills she incurred trying to save the child represented a huge financial strain for her family, delaying her reunion with her oldest children.

Sometimes entire families leave Venezuela together and travel with a few other families, seeking safety in numbers. Many migrants face long and uncertain journeys, further complicated by the daily risk of both petty and organized crime.

The migrants bring very little with them, and Watson has seen mothers sell their hair to wig-makers, hoping to make enough money to pay for the medicines their children badly need. And although the bolívar has been rendered useless as currency, the migrants have found new uses for it: stands selling handcrafts and decorations made of bolívars abound in Cúcuta.

"Not even dogs live like we do. The struggle and dishonor of leaving your land to avoid dying of hunger is hard," a Venezuelan migrant named Juan González told *La Opinión*, a Cúcuta-based newspaper.

González spent five weeks working at a shelter in La Parada before he decided to leave for fear of being deported, he told *La Opinión*—even though Colombia has not been deporting Venezuelans. When the 50-year-old González was interviewed, he had spent the last two days walking with a group of 15 and carrying all of his belongings in a bag on his back.

Desperate for jobs, migrants, however overqualified, tend to take the first opportunity that presents itself. One man Watson met selling water bottles in Lima used to be an engineer with his own office in Venezuela. Now, he makes more in a day than he used to make in a month before departing.

"I need to find a job again and be able to help my family," said Alejandro Rodriguez, another migrant interviewed by *La Opinión*. "[My family was] sad to see me go, but the blessing my mother gave me when I left will take care of me, God knows that I go ahead for them."

Rodriguez, just 19 years old at the time, had worked on a coffee plantation in Colombia the year before, returning to Venezuela periodically to bring money and food to his family. Now, he had crossed the border to provide for them again.

"People are moving because they're desperate and because they don't have any other option," Watson said.

THERE IS NO SIGN that the stream of people leaving Venezuela will slow anytime soon. Colombia's foreign minister has projected that as many as four million Venezuelan migrants will live in Colombia by 2021, costing the government nine billion dollars of social services.

Before leaving office in August, Juan Manuel Santos, Duque's predecessor, granted nearly half a million undocumented Venezuelans permission to stay and work in the country. Bahar described the Colombian government as making the best out of a complicated situation and pursuing the policies necessary to reap the economic benefits of the ongoing migration.

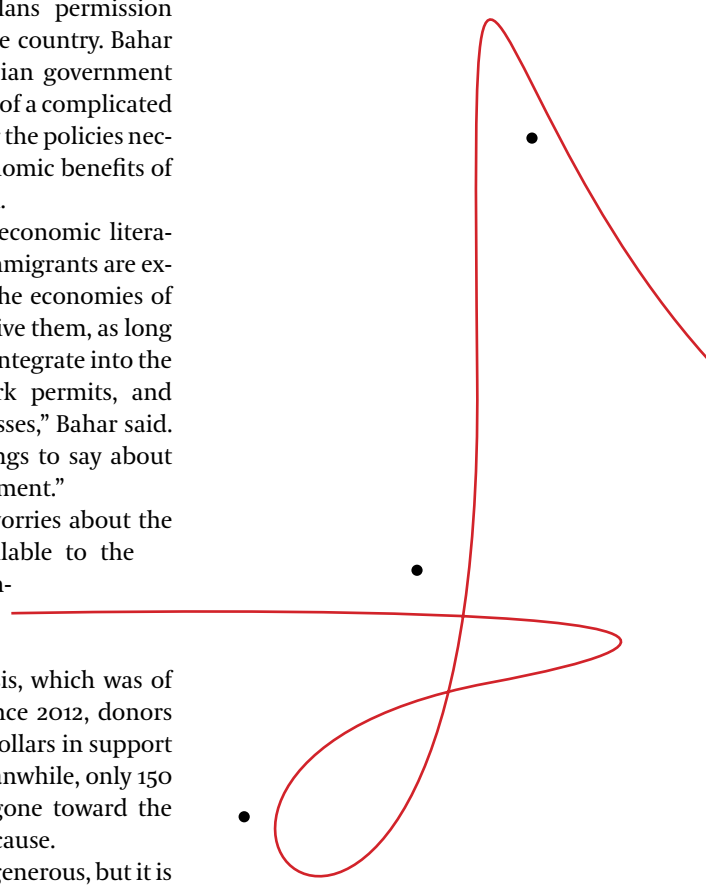
"There is a vast economic literature that shows that immigrants are extremely beneficial to the economies of the countries that receive them, as long as they are allowed to integrate into the economy, receive work permits, and start their own businesses," Bahar said. "I only have good things to say about the Colombian government."

But Bahar still worries about the international aid available to the countries receiving Venezuelan migrants. He made a comparison to the Syrian refugee crisis, which was of similar magnitude. Since 2012, donors have given 33 billion dollars in support of Syrian refugees. Meanwhile, only 150 million dollars have gone toward the Venezuelan migrants' cause.

"This aid is very generous, but it is not enough," Bahar explained. "In order for Colombia and the region to continue receiving Venezuelan migrants, they will need more help from the international community."

Father Bortignon's experience confirms this assessment—and he believes the state of Cúcuta's hospitals does too.

"They would need an infinite amount of state money to keep providing the medical treatments that migrants urgently need," he said. "We are quite creative at devising practical solutions, but there is a limit to what we can do."



BETTING ON BOOKS



BY **MAX GRAHAM**

CAN THE INDIE BOOKSTORE REVIVAL LAST?

BY OCTOBER 2017, Buffalo Street Books, a community-owned bookstore in Ithaca, New York, had been losing money—about 50,000 dollars per year—for nearly a decade. One hundred thousand dollars of debt had piled up; publishers had stopped selling books to the store. The shelves were growing barer every day, and the store didn't have sufficient funds to stay open until the new year. On the evening of Thursday, October 12, the board called an emergency meeting, inviting community members and the business' more than 700 shareholders to help brainstorm solutions.

That evening, rows of green plastic chairs filled the store's event space, as they do every week or so for an author talk or a communal gathering. Shareholders and concerned customers filed into a spacious, rectangular side room, lined with light wooden shelves holding a variety of nonfiction titles. Notes in hand, Rob Vanderlan, president of Buffalo Street's board, stood at the front, where the current events section collides with works of history.

Twenty years ago, Ithacans enjoyed more than 20 local independent bookstores. The city is home to two major colleges—Ithaca College and Cornell University—which, according to conventional wisdom in the publishing industry, makes it a particularly suitable place for book-

stores. But by the fall of 2017, Buffalo Street Books, located in a squat red-brick building attached to a local mall in the heart of the downtown, was the only independent bookstore left. National chains, like Borders and Barnes & Noble, had come to the city in the late '90s and had slowly squeezed local stores out of business. The convenience and low prices of Amazon—the giant online retailer that has grown every year since it was founded in 1995—proved impossible for many independent shops to compete with.

Originally called The Bookery II, Buffalo Street Books had been successful in the '80s and early '90s but started to face economic trouble when national competitors arrived. An optimistic new owner bought the store in 2005 and rebranded it with its current name. But he couldn't halt the decline in sales, Vanderlan told me. In 2011, Buffalo Street was on the market again. No one stepped up to buy it, so the community intervened, pooling its money—about 250 dollars a share—to convert it into a co-op, in a "somewhat quixotic, last-gasp effort to keep the store going," Vanderlan said, seven years later.

Heading into the meeting that Thursday in mid-October 2017, Vanderlan was nervous. He didn't know how many of the store's shareholders would show up. On average, only about 15 or 20 attended annual owner meetings; he feared this one would be no different.

He also dreaded delivering the bad news. "It felt like an admission of failure," he told me. "I didn't know if people would feel betrayed." He worried that owners would blame him personally. "How could you have let this happen?" he imagined they'd ask. "Why haven't you done X or Y or Z?"

Vanderlan's bookselling career began in 1990 with a gig at one of Borders' very first stores, in Philadelphia. He enjoyed working there; Borders had fewer than ten outlets at the time, and the company's stores ran like community-centric, autonomous independents, he told me. But in the five years Vanderlan was employed there, Borders went from operating nine stores to over 200. Company culture turned corporate. Vanderlan left for the University of Rochester for graduate school, and he moved to Ithaca three years later to write his dissertation. Compared to Rochester—where Vanderlan can't recall seeing "two interesting books in the 25 apartments we looked at"—in Ithaca every apartment he visited was stocked with books he had read or wanted to read. "It's just a community that is oriented around books, ideas, literature," he told me.

Although Vanderlan had settled on a career as a historian, his dissertation centered on an issue dear to many booksellers' hearts: the relationship between intellectualism and commerce. Vanderlan had little reason to suspect that the subject of his graduate studies would someday bear on his non-academic life—that he would land on the front lines of a battle with a corporate giant, in one of the defining cultural struggles of 21st-century America. Yet there Vanderlan stood, in 2017, upright despite his nerves, in khakis and a navy blue quarter-zip sweater, preparing to tell a crowd of loyal community intellectuals about their beloved bookstore's commercial failures. To remain open, the store needed—at a minimum—a fresh infusion of 75,000 dollars.

IN THE SPRING OF 2011, around the same time the Ithaca community rallied to take control of Buffalo Street, my parents purchased Politics and Prose, or P&P, an independent bookstore in Washington, D.C. P&P went up for sale not due to financial hardship, as Buffalo Street did, but because its two original owners were aging. Still, business had plateaued. The store was coasting on its celebrated reputation and leaning on a committed neighborhood following. It needed a burst of energy and a new batch of ideas.

When my parents told my older siblings and me, in the fall of 2010, that they had submitted a bid to buy P&P, I was startled. Thirteen years old at the time and an avid soccer player, I was decidedly *not* the kid crawling around the cozy children's section in the basement of P&P—or any bookstore, for that matter. "Don't tell mom and dad," I whispered to my siblings deviously, soon after our parents announced the news, "but I hate books." Besides, I thought, their plan didn't make sense: Why would a journalist (my dad) and a speechwriter (my mom), neither of whom had ever expressed interest in running a business, buy a bookstore?

Since opening in 1984, Politics and Prose, tucked away in a residential neighborhood in the heart of Northwest D.C., had become one of the District's main cultural destinations. Joyce Carol Oates once tweeted that P&P is "someplace between a bookstore & a small college." Ann Patchett, the prolific author and herself an indie-bookstore owner, wrote in *The New York Times* that P&P is "where the movers and shakers of our nation's capital come to see what's really going on." Several friends have told me, since my parents bought the store, that it's their favorite spot to shop, read, write, or hang out—and for some, their favorite spot, period.

Looking back, it's now easy to see why the store appealed to my parents. Over the years, as my book allergy subsided, I came to cherish P&P, not only as a token of familial pride but also as a space for dialogue and discovery, where tales and treatises and traveler's guides converge and where a gooey tomato-pesto grilled-cheese sandwich might facilitate a conversation with a friend. By the end of high school, I had packed boxes in the shipping room, shelved books on the floor, and manned the register at the front.

As writers and Washingtonians, my parents had long admired P&P, as Vanderlan had Buffalo Street, for its commitment to community and to intellectual and political discourse. But what my parents didn't fully realize when they bid for the store is that they

One experienced owner cautioned my dad, "You should be prepared to lose your entire investment. If you're O.K. with that, then go ahead and buy the store. It could at least be fun!"

were taking a tremendous risk—one they have not fully mitigated to this day. Although they researched independent bookselling before taking charge—my dad visited half-a-dozen indies during the bid process—they knew relatively little about the industry, and especially little about the mechanics of operating a bookstore. One experienced owner cautioned my dad, "You should be prepared to lose your entire investment. If you're O.K. with that, then go ahead and buy the store. It could at least be fun!"

Between 1995 and 2009, according to the American Booksellers' Association, a national trade organization for independent bookstores, the number of indies nationwide fell by nearly 50 percent, from more than 3,000 stores to just over 1,500. At first, in the '90s, the rise of big-box chains, like Borders, constricted the market, forcing small retail businesses across the country to close. After Amazon released the Kindle in 2007, many experts suspected e-books would push print books out of circulation. Some even predicted print books would become obsolete. When the Great Recession struck in 2008, the demise of the indie book industry seemed next to certain. My parents invested in a bookstore when the future of bookstores was ominous at best—when many stores were closing, and others, like Buffalo Street, were barely afloat.

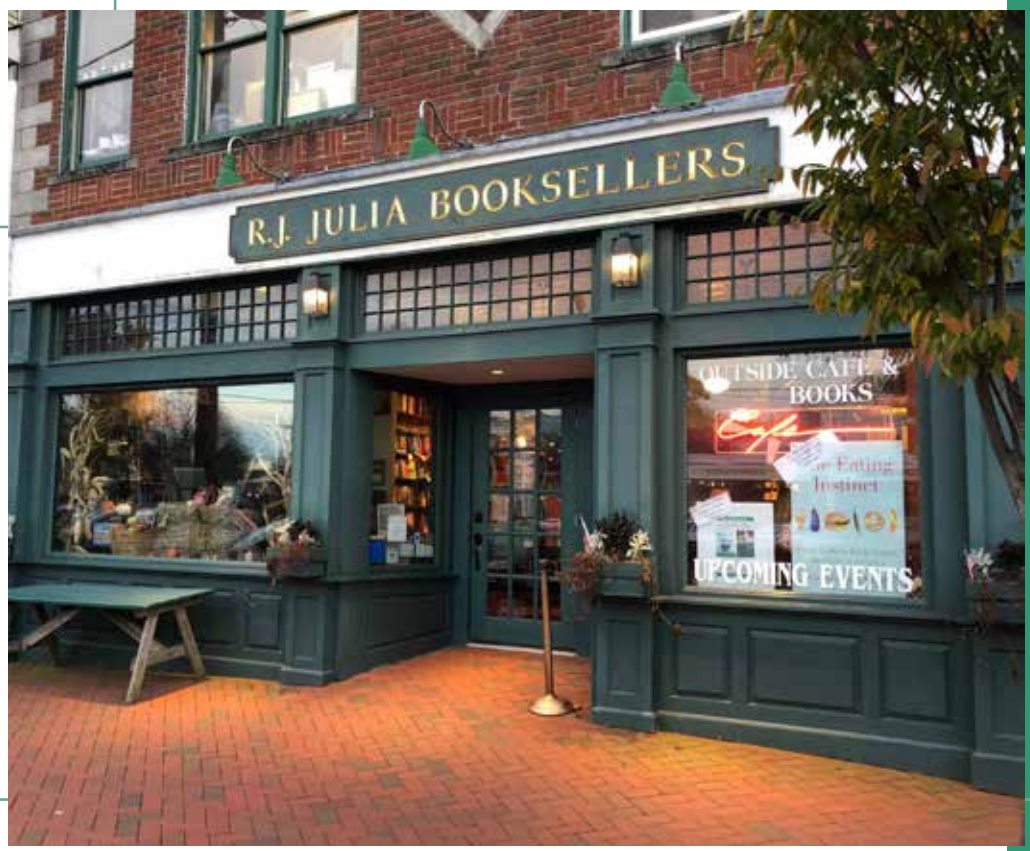
The struggling bookstore, like the one in the hit comedy *You've Got Mail*, is a well-known phenomenon. But what many people don't fully appreciate—and what my parents didn't know when they bought the store—is just how difficult bookstore management is in the age of Amazon. My dad recently told me, only half in jest, that he's not sure he would have bid on the store if he had been fully aware of the obstacles independent booksellers face.

As rent and employee wages rise, a bookstore, like any small business, needs to boost its revenue. Doing so, however, is uniquely difficult for bookstores. Most retailers can mark up prices to compensate for increased costs. The price of a book, though, is set by publishers and printed on every physical copy, meaning a bookseller can't adjust it to reflect the higher cost of living in, say, Washington relative to Ithaca.

Bookstores must be more than stores for books. Bookstore owners need to be especially innovative: since buying P&P, my parents have revamped the store's website and renovated its café, adding seating, expanding the menu, and obtaining a liquor license. They increased the number of literary class offerings and cultural trips to global destinations, like Cuba and France. They grew the number of author events to more than 700. In the last two years, they opened two branches at new developments around the city and expanded the flagship store by about 25 percent.

The most outlandish—or desperate—"business-savvy" idea my dad considered was "gifting" marijuana along with books. (Although selling marijuana isn't legal in D.C., a loophole in District law technically allows transferring less than an ounce, leading some local entrepreneurs to attach a small amount of weed to the sale of cheap items, like stickers, at wildly marked up prices.) Worried that our dad's drive for innovation had gone too far, my siblings and I quickly disabused him of the idea.

But my dad's marijuana scheme, however fanciful it may have been, highlighted the pressure bookstore owners feel to generate profit in creative ways. So far, my parents' approach has been effective: P&P has posted revenue gains every year since they bought it, with 2018 as the most profitable yet. But even a comparatively successful bookstore like P&P can



R.J. Julia Booksellers is located in Madison, CT. PHOTO BY **MAX GRAHAM**.

Independent bookstores forge connections with their local communities; they offer a more personalized and hands-on browsing experience, enabling a sense of discovery lacking online; and they provide a gathering space.

brick-and-mortar retail are suffering across the board.

Economists and media pundits have referred to the post-Great Recession business climate as the "retail apocalypse." In the book industry, Borders declared bankruptcy in 2011, and Barnes & Noble's total revenue has fallen by about 280 million dollars a year since 2012. Across other retail sectors, in 2017 alone, about 20 major companies declared bankruptcy—more than twice the number that did so in 2016. And other giants, like J.C. Penney and RadioShack, closed more than 100 stores.

But to a remarkable degree, the independent bookselling industry has defied conventional economics, experiencing a resurgence over the last decade. News articles about the industry often cite the fact that between 2009 and 2018, the number of independent bookstores in the U.S. grew by nearly 50 percent. On average, sales at independent bookstores have been up every year since the recession, and membership of the American Booksellers' Association has grown in each of the last nine years.

What makes the rebound of indie bookshops so astonishing is that the industry had been considered all but dead just ten years ago. So how did the indies make a comeback?

Ryan Raffaelli, a professor at Harvard Business School, has been researching this question for the last three years and thinks he has found an answer. Raffaelli studies the effects of technological "shocks" on retail industries. He observed the rise of the Kindle and e-books—and online shopping, more generally—as one such shock, on the traditional locally-sold-and-bought print book market.

The demand for retail products hasn't declined in recent years; overall retail spending has actually grown, along with GDP. Only the face of retail has changed. Raffaelli was intrigued by the fact that, despite the shifting landscape, indies have not only survived but are growing again. "The reason I've been studying the independent bookselling industry is because it is an anomaly," Raffaelli told me.

Before studying the bookstore market, Raffaelli researched the Swiss mechanical watch industry, which took a massive hit in the '70s after the invention of the digital watch. Economists predicted Swiss watches would die off—by 1983, two-thirds of Swiss watch industry jobs had disappeared—but by rebranding mechanical watches as high-end luxury items, the industry rebounded in the late '80s. Raffaelli has observed a similar phenomenon with independent bookstores.

"What you begin to see is a bifurcation of the industry where the indies represent this high experience, a chance for the consumer to engage on a set of very personal dimensions, versus Amazon, which is really about, 'Can I just get something quickly at the cheapest price?'" he told NPR's Paddy Hirsch in March.

Raffaelli, who has conducted hundreds of interviews with bookstore owners, customers, publishers, and authors, attributes the success of indies to the "three C's": community, curation, and convening. Independent bookstores forge connections with their local communities; they offer a more personalized and hands-on browsing experience, enabling a sense of discovery lacking online; and they provide a gathering space, hosting author talks, book signings, and school events.

Even so, Raffaelli told me, it's not impossible for a store like Buffalo Street Books, which checks all the above boxes, to be dealing with financial hardship. Small businesses face many challenges, like rising minimum wages and real estate rental prices, and even if an industry is growing overall, there still might be variability at the individual store level. Still, while some stores continue to struggle, Raffaelli is optimistic. In a November 2017 Harvard Business School video, Raffaelli, with boyish hair and a suppressed grin, remarked, "What independent booksellers do for us is that they really provide us with a story of hope."

ROXANNE COADY, ONE OF the most respected independent bookstore owners in the nation, doesn't exactly share Raffaelli's optimism. On a late October afternoon, we were driving from New Haven, where Coady lives, to her bookstore, R.J. Julia, in Madison, fewer than 30 minutes east along the Connecticut coast. While the "three C's" have certainly helped Coady stay in business, she thinks Raffaelli's positivity about the "indie revival" is premature. Like my parents' store, R.J. Julia relies on a fiercely loyal local customer base. Coady would be the first to acknowledge that her store's engagement with the Madison community has been vital to its financial success. But she also is a staunch pragmatist: Selling "community?" That's "bullshit." In her mind, her product is the same as Amazon's: A book is a book, and at the end of the day, that's what people go to her store to buy.

In 1990, Coady quit a successful 20-year career as a partner at BDO Seidman, a major New York City accounting firm, to fulfill her lifelong dream of opening a bookstore. A self-proclaimed "data person," she analyzed several towns along the New York-Boston corridor that she thought might be a good fit for the store, taking into careful consideration each town's distance from New York and Boston, its proximity to I-95, and its demographics, among other factors. She settled on Madison, a wealthy, aging community nearly equidistant from the big cities and close enough to the beach and the highway to attract tourists and commuters.

"What's the deal with Amazon and books?" I asked, as we cruised down I-95 in Coady's sleek navy-blue Volvo sedan. (I expected an impassioned response: Just about any mention of Amazon turns my rather-shy dad into a man of many words.) Coady, dropping an F-bomb or two, told me what Amazon means for indies—and

why the indie resurgence might be cause for only muted optimism.

Amazon has an advantage over independent bookstores on two fronts, she said: pricing and convenience. Amazon's business model is, simply speaking, to lose money or make only slim profits on retail. The company marks down prices to draw customers, gain market share, and appeal to investors. Only in recent years has it actually started to turn a profit; for the first seven years it was in business, the company consistently lost capital.

Unfortunately for local bookstores, the difference between their prices and Amazon's can be significant. Take the recent bestseller *Sapiens* by Yuval Noah Harari: On Amazon, a new paperback copy sells for 13.90 dollars; on R.J. Julia's website, it's 22.99 dollars—more than 50 percent more. Or Pete Souza's *Obama: An Intimate Portrait*, another bestseller: That's 28.99 dollars on Amazon, compared to 50 dollars at the average local bookstore.

Amazon can afford losses, or razor-thin profits, on book sales because its continued commercial growth and mammoth share of the retail market attract investors. As David Streitfeld of *The New York Times* reported in 2015, "Amazon's stock price doesn't seem to be correlated to its actual experience in any way." Lately, though, the company has been posting net gains—in the billions of dollars—mainly by hosting websites and storing data on its cloud computing service.

Amazon is, in terms of sheer market dominance, becoming a modern-day Standard Oil. In 2017, Lina Khan YLS '17, then a student at Yale Law School, published an article titled "Amazon's Antitrust Paradox" in the *Yale Law Journal*. Back when Rockefeller and the monopoly men were seizing markets, Congress passed laws designed to protect industries from the same sort of strategy that Amazon employs today: lowering prices to draw consumers away from competition. In the 1970s, though, a new school of corporate-friendly thought shifted the focus of antitrust policy away from market structure and toward consumer welfare, meaning that a company would be held responsible only if its practices hurt consumers—for example, if it *raised* prices, as a monopoly might do once it had annihilated all competition. This thinking has enabled Amazon to use the same predatory pricing scheme for which Standard Oil was broken up. Given Amazon's increasing success and retail dominance—by 2017 it controlled 46 percent of e-commerce in the U.S.—Khan's work gained immediate traction, including extensive coverage by national media outlets like *The New York Times* and *The Washington Post*, and it has sparked a new debate over the country's antitrust laws.

Pricing has always been an issue, Coady said, but now convenience is the "real competitive advantage" and, for indies, "the real danger." Amazon Prime, she told me, is like a "cudgel" to any store selling the same items. In June 2017, *Forbes* reported that 64 percent of households in the U.S. have Prime memberships, although more modest estimates say the percentage will be at about 50 by 2020. (Amazon has not disclosed the actual number.)

Go to Amazon's site, Coady said, and you can buy a book, or music, or games. "You come to our site: You want a book, or you want a book? Pick." She laughed. "These companies are geniuses at psychological manipulation."

Users, according to one study, increase their Amazon purchases by about 150 percent after subscribing to Prime. Coady doesn't believe independent bookstores can compete. Still, some have tried: Harvard Book Store, an almost century-old independent in Cambridge, Massachusetts, offers a same-day bicycle-delivery service, according to the owner, Jeff Mayersohn. The store also has a machine that produces out-of-print or self-published books in minutes.

Coady and I pulled up to the back of R.J. Julia. The store straddles the line between a vast shopping-mall parking lot lit by a Stop & Shop's neon lights and a row of small, high-end boutiques along Madison's main street.

We headed up a flight of forest-green stairs to Coady's office, which she shares with her general manager, Lori Fazio, and other staff. The bulletin-boarded walls were littered with writerly posters and book-themed quotes. "A bookstore is larger than the universe," one read. *Not as large as Amazon*, I thought with a grimace.

In 2017, Amazon reportedly sold just over 45 percent of all print books purchased in the U.S.; by comparison, indies make up about six percent of the print book market. If you factor in e-books and audiobooks, Coady said, Amazon's share is significantly higher, given that the company controls 65 percent of the e-book market.

Coady really is a data person. She has calculated how much money each square foot of her store makes, and she rearranges shelves and display tables according to their profitability. When you own a bookstore, Coady knows, every little detail counts. "The stores that were shitty," she said, "Amazon just pushed them over with its finger."

Coady's knack for business explains why she hired Fazio, an ex-saleswoman, as general manager. When Fazio took over in 2011, she focused on creating a culture in which the store's booksellers—the staff who interact with customers—acted more like salespeople, always asking customers if they would like to become store members, always dropping subtle hints about buying more.

"I'm more optimistic than



The interior of R.J. Julia Booksellers. PHOTO BY **MAX GRAHAM**.

Roxanne [Coady]," Fazio told me recently. "I do think that people are realizing the importance of downtown, community, and human interaction. I'm not worried yet."

R.J. Julia has survived—and like many independent bookstores, it has posted some of its best numbers in recent years. But there is a caveat: its in-store sales are declining. Luckily, "special sales," including books sold online to businesses and schools and at events, offset the in-store losses. Still, Coady worries about the future. She fears the day when the store won't pay for itself—even if online and off-site services remain profitable—and when the physical space won't be worth its keep.

BY THE TIME the October 2017 meeting at Buffalo Street Books commenced, nearly 120 owners and community book lovers had filed into the store. Every green plastic chair was occupied; bodies were cramped between the shelves and behind the seats. Vanderlan, the board president, remembers looking out across the room and not being able to see the whole audience. Some people could find space only where the store snaked like an "L" behind a wall.

Vanderlan announced to the crowd that someone had anonymously pledged 5,000 dollars, prompting a round of energetic applause. "The meeting was one of the more—I don't think this is hyperbolic—it was one of the more inspiring nights of my life," he told me.

The audience eagerly offered suggestions, including "themed festivals" and "pop-up" stores at public events. A local potter, Carol Schmook, designed and donated Buffalo Street Books mugs, which display, on one side, the store's logo—a buffalo reading a book—and say, on the other, "Thousands of books. Hundreds of owners. One great bookstore."

At the meeting, over 90 people signed up to volunteer at the store. And within six weeks after the meeting, the board raised nearly 90,000 dollars—15,000 more than it needed to survive for the near future. "The reception was very positive; people felt that they could make a difference and keep it going. At the time, there was a lot of optimism," said the store's founder and a current shareowner, Jack Goldman, who attended the meeting.

Still, a year later, Vanderlan said, "The question is very much up in the air whether we are on a sustainable path." The 2017 fundraising was "amazing," but it didn't pay down all of the store's debt. "It still left us in a hole."

In 2018, Buffalo Street Books made over 650,000 dollars in sales—about 17 percent more than in 2017. But the business has yet to break even. In October, the board, still 80,000 dollars in debt, decided to relinquish the store's event space to save on rent. Board members hope to expand online sales, which, at the moment, are virtually nonexistent.

"I'm deeply pessimistic and hopefully optimistic at the same time," Vanderlan said.

While Buffalo Street Books hangs in limbo, the U.S. independent bookstore industry continues to grow. Nationwide, indie book sales increased in 2018—for a tenth consecutive year—and more bookstores were founded than closed.

But you'd be mistaken if you thought my parents, or Roxanne Coady, or Rob Vanderlan, or any of their thousands of book-selling colleagues were sleeping soundly every night. There are debts to pay, sales-per-square-foot to track, authors to greet. But thankfully—for now, at least—there is no weed to sell.

A CIVIC DUTY

STUDENTS WANT SCHOOLS TO TEACH CITIZENSHIP

BY **EMILY JI**

OVER HER FOUR YEARS at Providence Career & Technical Academy (PCTA) in Rhode Island, high school senior Aleita Cook has studied kinematics, British literature, polynomial functions, and feminism. Before long, she will graduate and enter adulthood. Aleita, however, does not feel ready. "I'm worried about not having the proper education that I need to have a sustainable life," she said.

Despite its range of subjects, PCTA's curriculum has a glaring gap: the school offers no classes on civics. During her time in the Providence public school system, Aleita never learned how political parties function, how to register to vote, or how to vote. She considers all of these topics to be "basic things you need to know for the real world."

Ahmed Sesay, a senior at Classical High School in Providence, shares her view. He began freshman year with enthusiasm, aware that *U.S. News* ranks his high school as the number one public school in Rhode Island. But looking back, Ahmed is dissatisfied.

"I definitely feel that my school should have taught me more about my responsibilities as a citizen—voting, taxes, things like that," Ahmed told *The Politic*. "Schools should really take the time to educate people about how their actions and the things that they do affect society as a whole."

In November 2018, Aleita, Ahmed, and twelve other students filed a class action lawsuit against the state of Rhode Island for its lack of civic education. The plaintiffs argue that by failing to provide students with an adequate education, Rhode Island also fails to protect students' constitutional rights. Without civic knowledge, the plaintiffs believe, students are not properly prepared to exercise their rights—to vote, to serve on a jury, or to petition. They hope their case will make it to the Supreme Court.

The lawsuit is recent, but America's civic education crisis is not. The individuals involved in the case at hand, *Cook v. Raimondo*, are some of many Americans who have recognized the importance of civic knowledge and civic engagement over the years. The fight for civic education is complicated—and critical—say advocates, who believe comprehensive civics in schools could solve problems ranging from voter apathy to political polarization to educational inequality.

IN 2014, the National Assessment of Educational Progress (NAEP) found that in a civics assessment administered to eighth graders around the country, only 23 percent of students were at or above proficiency. Only 23 percent of eighth graders were likely to identify the purpose of the Declaration of Independence in a multiple choice question or provide examples of checks and balances.

A national survey released in 2018 by the Woodrow Wilson National Fellowship Foundation showed similarly unfavorable results: based on its findings, only one in three Americans would pass the U.S. citizenship test. More than half of respondents did not know which countries the U.S. fought against in World War II or the number of justices who serve on the Supreme Court.

Michael Rebell, the lead counsel for *Cook v. Raimondo* and a professor at Teachers College, Columbia University, believes that civic education is needed for an active, responsible citizenry. In an interview with *The Politic*, he described the dangers of a lack of civic education.

"[We] have a lot of voter apathy," Rebell said. "We have probably the lowest voter participation rate of the advanced democratic countries of the world. We have a lot of disinterest in civic involvement and community activities."

The Pew Research Center has conducted studies that confirm Rebell's concern: when compared to 32 other developed democratic countries around the world, the U.S. ranks 26th in voter turnout.

In 2014, another Pew Research Center study showed that Republicans and Democrats are further apart ideologically than at any point in the past two decades. "Many people have lost the ability or interest in speaking with people

with different views, trying to respectfully listen to what others say, reasoning with them to come up with ways of solving problems," Rebell said.

Ahmed thinks that civic education can help fix this. He believes that analyzing and discussing the American political system could promote a much more accepting environment. "I think teaching students how to engage in civil discussion with people who may disagree with them and to see the other person's humanity and to empathize even if you may disagree—that's a civic skill right there. It's teaching civility. It's teaching respect," he said.

Although every state requires high school students to complete some coursework in civics or social studies, not all states value or define civics the same way.

Fewer than half of all states require students to take a civics exam in order to graduate. While 39 states explicitly require a U.S. government course as a high school graduation requirement, the rest, including Kentucky, Oregon, Vermont, categorize civics as social studies—an umbrella discipline that encompasses history, economics, and geography. As a result, some students' social studies classes may only cover a limited range of civics topics, and often through the lens of history. For example, at Classical High School, where Ahmed studies, the only social studies graduation requirement is three years of history classes. "We would go over the three branches of government a little bit, but we never went into depth about how decisions are actually made and how people can affect them," Ahmed said.

Ahmed, Aleita, and Rebell believe that mandatory civics courses in school curricula could be one part of the solution. In the Civics Framework for the 2014 NAEP, experts explain that knowledge about politics, government, and civil society is essential to citizenship: if students understand the foundations of the American political system, the role of citizens, and how the government embodies the values and principles of American democracy, they will be better equipped to improve their communities and protect people's rights.

Additionally, the complaint for *Cook v. Raimondo* emphasizes the value of extracurricular activities in civic education. In the section titled "Civic Experiences," the complaint states, "Students need exposure to experiences that show them how politics and government actually work and how civic participation can influence social and political outcomes."

Student government, speech and debate, and mock trial can teach students to collaborate, speak effectively, and deliberate with team members. Through these activities, the plaintiffs argue, students not only gain experience communicating with people who hold different views, but they also develop a sense of agency and the tools to create change.

Field trips to local courts, state legislatures, and city councils count as another form of civic education, the complaint claims, "provid[ing] important opportunities for learning how political and civic institutions actually function...motivating students to become involved in political and civic activities later in life."

The plaintiffs who attend PCTA and Cranston High School West said they had "no or very limited options" for civics-related extracurricular activities at their schools. Woonsocket Middle School and Woonsocket High School Career and Technical Center—two other Rhode Island schools attended by plaintiffs—"provide no opportunities" for civics-related field trips or community engagement activities, their students report.

MANY ORGANIZATIONS around the country have tried to address the scarcity of comprehensive civic education in schools across the U.S.

In 2015, the Council on Public Legal Education in Washington state launched the Civic Learning Initiative, which partners with Washington courts, state officials, and educators to provide professional development courses for teachers and civic-learning programs for students. These programs include summer camps as well as voter mobilization activities. Another product of this collaboration has been iCivicsWA, a curriculum on icivics.org that teaches civics with a focus on Washington's government and political history.

Similarly, in 2014, Chief Judge Robert Katzmann of the U.S. Court of Appeals for the Second Circuit launched Justice For All: Courts and the Community, a civic education initiative based out of the Thurgood Marshall United States Courthouse in New York City. Justice For All aims to "increase public understanding of the role and operations of the courts," according to its website. The initiative organizes courthouse tours,

ONLY 23 PERCENT OF EIGHTH GRADERS WERE LIKELY TO IDENTIFY THE PURPOSE OF THE DECLARATION OF INDEPENDENCE IN A MULTIPLE CHOICE QUESTION.

visits from judges and attorneys to schools, classes called Library Labs that teach information literacy and legal research, and school field trips to naturalization ceremonies. Its new Learning Center, which features interactive touchscreen exhibits about the Constitution, the court system, and Thurgood Marshall, was recently opened to the public.

According to Justice For All's 2018 report, the initiative gave approximately 10,000 students the opportunity to visit district courts in the Second Circuit, and the Thurgood Marshall Courthouse also hosted 12 Library Labs. "If you remember your own high school experience, you were dying to get your hands on something real. Here it is," one high school teacher said of the labs.

In search of civic education, Aleita and Ahmed have turned to a different type of organization: the Providence Student Union (PSU), a nonprofit in Rhode Island that promotes student activism. From joining PSU to becoming a youth organizer—her current staff position—Aleita has discovered answers to many of her civics-related questions, such as how to register to vote and how to organize walkouts, marches, and protests. "PSU helped me boost my knowledge on politics," she said. "It has helped me become the activist I am today."

PSU was formed in response to Hope High School's 2010 plans to change its block schedule, which would have given students fewer opportunities to take elective courses. Students at Hope scheduled meetings with school board members and district officials, organized a schoolwide walkout with 400 participants, and worked with local attorneys to file a lawsuit that made its way to the Rhode Island Supreme Court. The lawsuit argued that the schedule change reduced the amount of "common planning time"—time for professional development and lesson planning—which defied state education regulations. Ultimately, the court sided with the students.

Since the success of the Hope High School block schedule campaign, PSU has started chapters in five Providence schools. PSU student members have organized to prevent the closure of Dr. Jorge Alvarez High School, to increase the number of students eligible for bus passes, and to include ethnic studies classes in school curricula. PSU members have used strategies like testifying at school board meetings, rallying outside the Providence School Department, and gathering signatures for petitions to achieve their goals.

Ahmed, who is also a youth organizer at PSU, told *The Politic* that PSU provided him with valuable civic engagement opportunities that were not offered in school and motivated him to become more politically active.

"PSU has definitely encouraged me to realize that there is power in numbers—there's power in figuring out what people want to see and the needs that people have and trying to meet them. PSU has definitely given me more strength in feeling that I am able to facilitate discussions and get people to voice their grievances," Ahmed said.

Zack Mezera, the executive director at PSU, graduated from Brown University in 2013. He hopes that exposure to civic education will have a long-lasting impact on students.

"Hopefully students get involved with PSU and feel that they can continue that kind of work throughout the rest of their lives," Mezera told *The Politic*. "Students [involved with PSU] may go to the school board in 2019 and it's their first time there and they figure out how to testify and gain experience. Then in 2031, or whenever they have kids and there's a problem at school, they know where to go."

Nevertheless, Aleita and Ahmed do not feel that PSU is a sufficient substitute for civics classes. The plaintiffs and their lawyers in *Cook v. Raimondo* strongly believe that all students have a right to a civics education *in school*, and that this education is crucial in preparing students to be capable citizens.

In an interview with *The Politic*, Jennifer Wood, an attorney for the plaintiffs in *Cook v. Raimondo*, emphasized that programs like PSU and Justice For All are "only able to reach a small fraction of the students enrolled in public schools."

Wood added, "It would be like saying we're going to have volunteers teach math after school—we're not going to teach math during the school day. If I suggested that we take that approach as a nation, people would think, 'That's ridiculous.'"

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ASHLEY SANTACRUZ and Yousof Abdelreheem, two seniors at John Bowne High School in New York City, have benefitted from a combination of in-class civic education and civics-related extracurricular activities. Both students are part of the John Bowne Law Institute, a four-year program at their high school that prepares students for future careers in law.

Starting in freshman year, Ashley and Yousof have taken classes about the Constitution, criminal justice, and legal research and writing through the Law Institute. With the launch of Justice For All in New York, they have had opportunities to take field trips to the Thurgood Marshall Courthouse and listen to judges speak at their high school. During senior year, John Bowne students who are not in the Law Institute take Participation in Government, a civics course that is required for graduation.

Ashley said her high school civics classes helped foster her interest in politics and activism. "The resources that were given to us were predominantly academic, and throughout my years in high school, I have grown to have a love for law. I want to do more, which is why I am now a student at the Columbia University Law high school program," she told *The Politic*, referring to the Columbia Law School High School Law Institute. "I also want to pursue a career in law."

Both Ashley and Yousof participate in mock trial and moot court competitions, as well as a variety of other activities. For example, Ashley is a representative in the Queens North Borough Council. She works with other student leaders to improve school safety, public transportation, and guidance counseling. The Council also promotes Respect For All, a New York City Department of Education (DOE) anti-bullying and anti-harassment initiative. Yousof is a member of the School Diversity Advisory Group, a group of students and educators handpicked by New York City Hall that evaluates the DOE's plan to promote school integration and recommends additional strategies.

Veronica Thomas, a teacher at John Bowne High School, believes in the importance of teaching civics to students. Ashley and Yousof, she said, "are a testament to the fact that if you do that in ninth grade, it will encourage students to go beyond the resources that we provide here for them in the schools."

Additionally, Yousof pointed out that regardless of whether or not students end up with careers in government or politics, civic education is beneficial for life in general. "Doing civic engagement through the school itself and through other opportunities that Ashley and I have had has instilled confidence—confidence that you can invoke change," Yousof said.

The idea that civic education in school can inspire students to become active citizens in their communities is a major theme at John Bowne. The plaintiffs and lawyers of *Cook v. Raimondo* hope to replicate this model in schools across the U.S. In Providence, Aleita and Ahmed were able to learn about activism and civic engagement through PSU, and Wood commends nonprofit organizations like PSU for enriching students' lives. "However, that doesn't relieve the public school system from the obligation to provide the baseline, to provide a robust and adequate civic education," Wood told *The Politic*. Only then can students "build on that foundation and follow their own areas of interest," she added.

Civic education teaches students that the judicial branch is powerful—and responsible for interpreting the law and making long-lasting, precedent-setting decisions. The plaintiffs and lawyers hope that eventually, the U.S. Supreme Court will recognize the value of civic education and declare that it is a right for all students. "When you leave high school, you should know the basic things you need to know for the real world," said Aleita. "If you don't know what's going on, how can you change it?"

KNOW FOR THE REAL WORLD

KNOW FOR

“IF YOU DON'T KNOW WHAT'S GOING ON, HOW CAN YOU CHANGE IT?”

A CIVIC DUTY

“IF YOU DON'T KNOW WHAT'S GOING ON, HOW CAN YOU CHANGE IT?”

A CIVIC DUTY

“IF YOU DON'T KNOW WHAT'S GOING ON, HOW CAN YOU CHANGE IT?”

A CIVIC DUTY

“IF YOU DON'T KNOW

Counting the Days

The Coast Guard's Shutown Pantry in Photos

BY **MATT NADEL**

NONPROFIT ORGANIZATIONS dedicated to supporting Coast Guard officers opened a makeshift food pantry at the United States Coast Guard Academy in New London, Connecticut, during the government shutdown. Filled with light from a floor-to-ceiling window overlooking the Thames River, Leamy Hall—the Academy's "morale, well-being, and recreation" space—was crowded with rows of folding tables converted into supermarket aisles. The pantry welcomed all employees of the unfunded Department of Homeland Security, supplying them with donated groceries, gift cards, and cash.



Items in cart at food pantry, U.S. Coast Guard Academy, Connecticut.

ON DECEMBER 22, 2018, President Donald Trump and lawmakers in Congress failed to agree on an appropriations bill to fund the federal government for the 2019 fiscal year, initiating the third government shutdown of Trump's term. Government employees deemed "nonessential" were furloughed, while essential employees, including members of the Coast Guard, were required to work without pay. During the shutdown, Coast Guard officers missed two paychecks each.

ON JANUARY 25, 2019, Trump signed a bill to fund the government for three weeks. After 35 days, he ended the longest government shutdown in U.S. history, promising that federal employees would receive back-pay "very quickly, or as soon as possible."



Officer stacks cans.



Hygiene products.



Officer pushes cart.



Tiger and her support dog, Duke.



Officer loads items into cart.



“I will make sure that all employees receive their back pay very quickly, or as soon as possible. It will happen very fast.”

President Donald J. Trump



TOP: Child learns to shake hands.

RIGHT: Officer poses beside cereal.

KILLING CHILDREN

Reflections on Sierra Leone's Civil War

BY **PETER ROTHPLETZ**

"FROSTY THE SNOWMAN" was playing over the cafe's sound system when Francis said he was ready to talk about his childhood. "I wasn't a soldier," he explained after finishing the last bite of his second breakfast sandwich. "Soldier is the wrong word."

Francis and I had connected through a friend of a friend, and we spent several mornings in the latter half of December getting to know each other over cheap New Haven coffee and bacon-egg-and-cheeses. He was exceedingly polite in all of our interactions—always insisting on opening doors or pulling out chairs for me. Any mention of Sierra Leone, however, seemed to make him skittish. He didn't like talking about his life prior to immigrating to the United States, in the mid-2000s. In fact, he only agreed to speak with me on the condition of anonymity—"Francis" is not his real name. Given the subject matter, I felt this was a reasonable concession.

"How old were you when you got involved with the war?" I asked toward the end of our first meeting.

"Fourteen," he replied.

THERE'S A POPULAR, somewhat trite dinner-party refrain, alternately attributed to Einstein, Hoover, and Roosevelt, that "old men start wars but young men fight them." However, in Sierra Leone's decade-long civil war, it wasn't just young men who did the fighting: it was children, too. Some 11,000 boys and girls, in fact, are believed to have participated in the conflict. Those that survived are now in their thirties and forties, and they spend each day reflecting on atrocities that most of the world seems to have forgotten.

When the Revolutionary United Front (RUF) crossed the Liberian border into Sierra Leone in March 1991, its ranks were comprised of little more than 100 guerrillas and a small, poorly armed contingent of mercenaries from Burkina Faso. In theory, the group was a revolutionary force—an insurgency driven by the prospect of toppling Sierra Leone's relatively weak and unloved head of state, Joseph Saidu Momoh. Years of economic decline had turned a majority of the country against Momoh, and news of a rebellion sweeping across the remote, eastern districts was initially celebrated by many Sierra Leoneans. But their support dissolved once it became clear the RUF had no interest in winning over the local population.

"It was a campaign of terror," Corinne Dufka explained to me in late December. Dufka was the Human Rights Watch representative in Sierra Leone between 1999 and 2003; she spent most of her time documenting RUF atrocities through photography and hundreds of interviews. We played a spotty game of email-tag for several weeks while she was investigating ethnic clashes in central Mali. Later, once she returned to Washington, we spoke over the phone.

"The RUF used brutality as a way to compensate for the lack of numbers in their ranks, she told me. "They used fear and intimidation to control communities."

Systematic rape, public executions, and forced amputations were employed in combination to maximize panic among civilians. The 1990s saw a wave of ruthless, indiscriminate violence crash across the African continent, but the tactics of the RUF were exceptionally cold-blooded.

"They used games to terrorize people," Dufka explained. "They would arrive at a town and bring out the entire community. Then they would give a random person a riddle, and if the person couldn't answer it, their entire family was killed in front of everyone… as if the limb amputations weren't enough, they also exercised horrific psychological torture. There were some cases where they forced parents to choose between their children," she said. "One would be executed and the other would be spared…and the parent had to decide."

"That sounds like *Sophie's Choice*," I told Dufka.

"You have to choose between indignation and horror."

"Yes, it was very similar to *Sophie's Choice*," she said grimly. "I documented several cases of that. … Children were afforded no protection."

It's fair to say that targeting young people was a trademark of the RUF's terror regime. In addition to often serving as pawns in the group's torture games, boys and girls were routinely abducted and turned into military assets. According to Dufka, kidnapping became the rebels' primary tactic in bolstering their ranks. While the girls were often utilized as "wives" or sex slaves for RUF higher-ups, the boys were pushed onto the battlefield.

"I NEVER KILLED ANYONE," Francis asserted toward the end of our first meeting. He gripped my hand to make sure I was listening. "I saw other boys do it, but I never did. … They wanted me to kill people. They gave me drugs and guns and they took everything until I had nothing, but it didn't work. It didn't work with me."

Francis would reiterate these assertions a number of times in later conversations. He'd bring them up at seemingly random moments—perhaps just to remind me. It was clear he took some degree of pride in having endured his RUF conditioning while so many others lost themselves.

Once conscripted, children were exposed to a wide range of indoctrination methods. "They had to control every part of them to stop them from running away," Dufka said. "They did that by way of intimidation, they did that by way of strategically breaking the child's ties with their community. They forced them to perpetrate atrocities against members of their own family. They forced them to kill their own parents so the children had no one to run away to."

Horrifically, family annihilation was often only the first step in the RUF's broader "isolation process." Rebel soldiers would proceed to brand abductees' chests and arms with hot razors or broken glass, destroying any hope of easy reintegration within society. Then, after the RUF marked the children's bodies, they moved on to their minds.

"Marijuana was used a lot," Dufka explained to me. "Many children described having it put in their food after they were abducted. I interviewed a few kids who talked about just how disorienting that was for them."

Marijuana, along with alcohol, was the primary tool the RUF used to keep new recruits numb and compliant. Early training sessions with firearms—or other efforts to desensitize the children to violence—were preceded by heavy drug use. Later, once the boys were ready to be sent into battle, their commanders would allegedly alter the pharmaceutical load, exchanging marijuana for doses of cocaine that would be administered through small skin incisions.

"The drugs made boys crazy," Francis confirmed. "They made the boys worse than crazy. I mean they made the boys want to kill people. Your family is dead, you have nothing left, but you have the drugs. So maybe the drugs make the killing easy. Or maybe the drugs are the only thing you have, so you kill for more drugs. Or maybe it's both."

There are some who cast doubt on cocaine's reported role in the conflict, however. Daniel Bergner, a contributing writer for *The New York Times Magazine*, was on the ground in Sierra Leone between 2000 and 2002. To this day, he believes the stimulant may have been nothing more than a comfortable explanation for the otherwise incomprehensible.

"This was a horrific war, not in numbers but in atrocities, and the West, the reporters, the UN, and NGOs were desperate to explain what was happening," he said. They would attribute it to the insanity of RUF leaders, and then they would attribute it to the megalomania of Charles Taylor. For a while, they attributed it to Gaddafi. And in the midst of that

there was the narrative that what was impelling these child soldiers to commit these atrocities was the drugs. … I feel like there's way too little evidence for the assertion that drug use allowed for the atrocities, but it crept into the popular narrative.

"Cocaine is expensive," Bergner continued. "Sierra Leone was extraordinarily poor. This idea that there was a whole lot of cocaine running around somehow… I have a hard time believing that."

When I presented Bergner's argument to Corinne Dufka, she hesitated to take a side on the matter. "I can't really speak to cocaine," she said. "Most of the children I spoke to talked about marijuana, but there were some people who did describe having white powder put in their noses. I'm not sure."

Dufka did acknowledge Bergner's broader contention that problems exist within the "popular narrative" around Sierra Leone and the RUF. In the rush to document what was happening on the ground and explain why it was taking place, it's possible some viewed nuances in the conflict as obstacles in the storytelling process.

"There was no simple divide between good and bad," Bergner told me. "It's a big mistake to attribute the atrocities simply to the RUF. There were atrocities committed by RUF, by government soldiers, and by government allies. It was a complete mess."

Dufka echoed this idea, mentioning how both the Sierra Leone military and pro-government militias exhibited reprehensible behavior throughout the war. She singled out the Kamajors, in particular. Originally a loose collective of tribal hunters, the group came to be seen as a reliable civil-defense force by the government. Cooperation intensified during the latter half of the war, despite the fact the militia made extensive use of child soldiers.

"The Kamajors certainly recruited children," Dufka told me. "They practiced extrajudicial executions too. Their crimes were not equatable or on the same scale with the RUF, but they absolutely committed atrocities." By some estimates, approximately five thousand of the 11,000 children who were conscripted into the war fought for pro-government defense forces.

"No, there were no really good guys," Francis told me. "It was mostly bad guys and badder guys. The whole thing had a lot of bad."

IN MANY WAYS, "Operation No Living Thing" served as the climax of Sierra Leone's civil war. The campaign, launched on January 6, 1999, was a surprise attack on the country's capital of Freetown, but it ultimately stretched into a three-week occupation.

RUF rebels stormed the eastern edge of the city before dawn, toting machetes, imported RPGs, and Kalashnikov rifles. There's no way to properly describe what took place over the next several hours. It was a massacre, of course, but words and vague statistics fail to convey the hellscape that unfolded. Eyewitness reports chronicle the insurgents rounding up entire neighborhoods to be tortured, mutilated, and slaughtered.

The violence was ruthless and indiscriminate, and as the invasion force pushed further west, from Calaba Town to Kissy, the brutality seemed to escalate into outright sadism; civilians were taunted while they were hacked to death. Dufka's Human Rights Watch report on the incursion cited several instances of infants being thrown into burning buildings and toddlers being subjected to systematic limb amputations. To some, though, the most horrific aspect of "Operation No Living Thing" was not how many children were victimized—it was how many children perpetrated the violence. In the report, Dufka wrote: "child combatants armed with pistols, rifles, and machetes actively participated in killings and massacres, severed the arms of other children, and beat and humiliated

"It was mostly bad guys and badder guys. The whole thing had a lot of bad."

men old enough to be their grandfathers... they were known and feared for their impetuosity, lack of control, and brutality."

"I witnessed more atrocities during that period than at any other point," General David Richards said, reflecting on the RUF occupation. The former head of the British armed forces was in Freetown in January 1999, conducting a brief review of Sierra Leone's military for Prime Minister Tony Blair. I communicated with General Richards—who repeatedly insisted that I call him David—extensively throughout the fall. We emailed back and forth for several days, before I finally coaxed a Skype interview out of him. Approximately a week after I had first made contact, we met face to face, albeit on opposite sides of the Atlantic.

"You have to choose between indignation and horror," Richards replied when I asked how he preserved his sanity in the midst of so much evil. The general led a second, brief reconnaissance trip in Freetown throughout February 1999 and then a much larger evacuation operation in May 2000 as the conflict worsened. It was during the latter mission that Richards made the possibly career-ending, unilateral decision to go beyond his official mandate and intervene in the war.

"I had a battalion of the Parachute Regiment, 42 commando Royal Marines, some Special Air Service special forces, and a few Naval hands that had come ashore from the support vessels. That was it," Richards told me. "And if I had more than one or two British casualties, I was finished because my bosses in London would have realized what I was doing."

Determined to stop the atrocities he had witnessed in 1999, Richards contacted potential partners in the region. "I ultimately had to create what we called the 'Unholy Alliance,'" he explained. "It ended up being the rump of the Sierra Leone army, some West Side Boys, who were a very unpleasant lot, and the Kamajor militia, who were loyal to the government but were also capable of methods that I abhorred."

In the weeks that followed, Richards and his British personnel rarely came into direct contact with the RUF. "That was by design," he told me. "Most of the hand-to-hand and close quarter fighting had to be between Sierra Leoneans." However, Richards was constantly reminded of the gravity of his situation—he was waging a war against children.

"When you traveled, you would come across the wounded or the dead and realize that some of them are very young. And when I went through areas where fighting had been, sure enough, there were one or two that would be in their early teens. But you don't feel disgusted with yourself," he asserted. "You feel disgusted with the men who put the young people in that position, and it makes you more determined to stop them."

Despite the topic of our conversation, I only witnessed Richards lose his temper—or express any significant emotion—once. I had asked him what he thought of the RUF leader Foday Sankoh, the one-time army corporal and wedding photographer who first brought the insurgency's guerillas across the Liberian border. Richards didn't hold back: "Sankoh was possibly the most monstrous opponent I ever faced. I'm not aware of many warlords that would stoop to using children as weapons. He was deeply calculating, sanctimonious, and almost cheerfully evil. He played on terror in a way I haven't really seen elsewhere. He was a bully. He was a dog."

GENERAL RICHARDS' ACTIONS ultimately saved Sierra Leone. Government forces captured Sankoh less than a month after the start of the intervention and proceeded to push RUF factions back into the eastern recesses of the country. Leaderless and facing mounting pressure from Guinea, Nigeria, and local militias, the rebels did not last long. Sierra Leone President Ahmad Kabbah formally declared an end to the civil war on January 18, 2002.

"But it's not over just because they say it's over," Francis clarified for me. "They stopped the RUF but I didn't have a home or a family anymore. I didn't have a place to go."

Francis claimed he escaped from his unit sometime in December 1999 or January 2000 and made his way to a camp for demobilized RUF child soldiers in Makeni, the largest city in the Northern Province of Sierra Leone. Assuming his dates are correct, this would have been approximately a year after his abduction during the 1999 occupation of Freetown. He claims to have stayed at the camp for only a few days before joining a group of families headed to Guinea. Francis asked that I not include how he eventually made it to the U.S.

"I still have nightmares," he told me during our last meeting. "I know I am safe here, but they will never go away...and they make sleeping very hard. Imagine if you had dreams of your mother dead in front of you or of dead neighbors and dead friends."

"I'm so sorry this happened to you," I remember saying to Francis before we parted ways for the final time.

"Don't be sorry for me," Francis replied. "I got out. Other boys did not."

Today, according to Brookings, there are an estimated 300,000 minors serving in armed groups around the world—with an average age of 12 years old.

The Discrimination Debate



Asian Americans and Ivy League Admissions

BY **IAN MOREAU**

WARREN ZHANG '19, a Yale economics major, has a lot to look forward to. The son of two Bay Area professionals, he secured a highly coveted spot at Yale after four years at a competitive public high school. Now, with graduation just months away, he plans on working in the tech industry, and Yale has prepared him well.

Critics of race-conscious admissions policies would argue that, due to affirmative action, Ivy League success stories like Zhang's are becoming less common. But Zhang, a Chinese American, is among the roughly 70 percent of Asian Americans who support affirmative action.

"The method of using race-based preferences is effectively a form of racial discrimination. Just because you're using it to fight existing racial discrimination doesn't make it just," Zhang said. "But at the same time, these societal problems are real, so leaving them alone and pretending they don't exist is, I think, more unjust."

IN NOVEMBER 2014, the anti-affirmative action group Students for Fair Admissions (SFFA) slammed Harvard with a lawsuit alleging a pattern of discrimination against Asian American applicants. In August 2018, the Department of Justice, led by former Attorney General Jeff Sessions, lent its support to the more than 20,000 plaintiffs—students, parents, and others—involved in the case.

Around the same time, numerous Asian American civil rights and advocacy organizations, including the Asian American Coalition for Education (AACE), filed a series of complaints against elite universities with the federal government. In response, the Department of Justice and Department of Education's Office of Civil Rights launched two joint investigations into the admissions practices of Harvard and Yale, triggering a storm of media coverage and an uptick in student activism on college campuses in support of affirmative action.

These investigations do not represent the only time that affirmative action policies at universities have come under attack. Conservative and anti-affirmative action activists have worked through courts and popular referendums for decades, leading successful campaigns to ban race-conscious admissions in states like California, Florida, and Michigan.

But given that past efforts have focused on public universities, the Harvard lawsuit and current joint investigations mark the first time that the admission of Asian Americans at elite private institutions like Harvard and Yale has been placed under the proverbial legal microscope—and has been the focus of a nationwide debate over affirmative action.

Those at the AACE point to data that corroborates claims of discriminatory admissions practices. A 2008 study published in *InterActions: UCLA Journal of Education and Information Studies* revealed that state bans on affirmative action policies at public universities led to increases in Asian Americans' odds of acceptance. The study mostly examined admissions data from California, where affirmative action was banned through a 1996 state referendum. At the University of California, Berkeley, the share of Asian American first-year students rose from roughly 37 percent in 1995 to roughly 47 percent in 2005. In an interview with *The Chronicle of Higher Education,* David Colburn, a former provost at the University of Florida and one of the study's authors, stated, "Asian Americans were discriminated against under an affirmative-action system."

Historically, most complaints of race-based discrimination have been filed by white plaintiffs. After Abigail Fisher, a white woman, was rejected by the University of Texas at Austin in 2008, she unsuccessfully attempted to overturn the uni-

"The institutions that we support and attend should generally look like the people that they draw from. To me, Yale should look like America."

versity's affirmative action policies in two cases that eventually reached the Supreme Court. Bert Rein, the seasoned lawyer who represented Fisher both times, strongly believes that the facts are on the AACE's side against both Harvard and Yale.

Referencing the number of Asian American admits at California's public universities before and after the 1996 referendum, Rein asserted that affirmative action policies have been proven to significantly harm Asian Americans. "With Harvard and Yale, if you look at the scores, the grades, as much objective evidence as you can get, the performance of the Asian admits is way above the average," Rein told *The Politic*. "So the question is: why are you turning away so many?"

Brian Taylor, managing director of Ivy Coach, an elite college admissions counseling firm, thinks he has an answer.

"Asian American applicants so often present similar profiles," Taylor told *The Politic*. "In many instances, I would argue that this profile is a template profile. A Chinese American student who excels in math and in a string instrument and runs track—it's a profile that college admissions officers have seen before. It doesn't 'wow' them."

Taylor says that Asian American applicants are primarily put at a disadvantage when they don't present themselves as unique. "That's true of Asian American applicants, it's true of Caucasian applicants, African American applicants," he insisted. Rather than focusing on racial discrimination, Taylor advises his clients to present themselves as distinct individuals. His advice is simple: be interesting.

Rita Wang '19, an Asian American Yale student who has advocated for the creation of an Asian American studies major, takes offense at such characterizations of Asian Americans, which she considers stereotyping. She worries that popular narratives about Asian Americans ignore key history—in particular, the government's role in choosing which immigrants are welcome. "If you become more critical about Asian academic success, you'll see that a lot of it is due to U.S. immigration law," she told *The Politic*. The Hart-Celler Act of 1965, for example, allowed many Asians to immigrate to the U.S. during the Cold War for their skills in math, science, and engineering. "The U.S. very selectively chose only academically successful Asians," Wang explained.

Wang believes that misconceptions about Asian Americans contribute to the "model minority myth," the belief that Asian Americans are a successful ethnic minority due to an inherent work ethic and academic ability. In a *Yale Daily News* opinion article defending affirmative action, she explained how the model minority myth "was not created to uplift Asian-American communities. Rather, it was explicitly crafted to push down Black, Latinx and Native Americans."

But Zhang believes that the stereotype of the high-achieving East Asian student contains some degree of truth. Describing his Bay Area high school to *The Politic*, Zhang noted that many Chinese American students in the Bay Area are remarkably similar, children of highly educated immigrant parents who push their kids toward a narrow set of academic and extracurricular pursuits.

"Although it's obviously not true of every student, when the stereotype is ingrained deeply enough in the culture, it is necessary to do some things to buck that trend," said Zhang. "When you're dealing with so many high-achieving students who look very similar on paper and you have a very limited number of spots, it eventually comes down to this deep question of differentiation."

But Sidney Carlson-White '21, a Black student at Yale and a dedicated activist who supports affirmative action, contends that stereotypes regarding Asian academic overachievement are not only harmful—they're racist. "To some degree, Harvard is saying, 'Yes, this person might be smart, this person might have done well on their SAT and have a high GPA, but they have no personality,'" he said in an interview with *The Politic*. "Where does that come from other than blatant racism?"

ENVISIONING A MORE "merit-based" admissions process, the AACE has sought to abolish race-conscious admissions policies since the group was founded in 2014. Alongside groups like Students for Fair Admissions, the AACE has been at the forefront of the current controversy surrounding Harvard and Yale.

In an interview with *The Politic*, AACE President Yukong Zhao argued that affirmative action lacks a legal basis. "It's really a moral issue," he said. "It's racial discrimination, explicitly banned by the Civil Rights Act." Zhao and the AACE also claim that race-conscious admissions are unconstitutional and violate the Fourteenth Amendment.

However, James Forman Jr., a Pulitzer Prize-winning Yale law professor who specializes in constitutional and criminal law, defended affirmative action. "If you look back at the Supreme Court decision for *Bakke*, the first big affirmative action case, it was determined that, legally, this redressing of historical discrimination wasn't a compelling interest sufficient to justify affirmative action," he told *The Politic*. "There are a lot of people, myself included, who think that that was a mistake, who think that historical discrimination and responding to historical discrimination is and should be considered a compelling interest that universities can pursue."

While Forman asserted that affirmative action could counter historical discrimination, Kirk Kolbo, who represented plaintiffs challenging the University of Michigan's affirmative action policies in two separate Supreme Court cases, disagreed. Kolbo said that in the past, affirmative action was used to discriminate against Jewish applicants. "It's like 50 years ago, when Harvard had a quota when they didn't want as many Jewish students," he said. "That's how they established the limit." For Jewish applicants, he added, "They basically had separate admissions standards."

MATTHEW LE '20, a Vietnamese American Yale student, argues that the benefits of affirmative action outweigh its drawbacks. "Diversity: it's not something you can ever quantify. There's no metric," Le told *The Politic*. "But having Yale, if it's going to be this premier institution educating America's best, be a closer cross-section of what America is...that's important. To not have that diversity represented here, this school would not reflect this nation and the people in it."

Carlson-White concurred. "I believe in diversity as a categorical and objective good," he said. "The institutions that we support and attend should generally look like the people that they draw from. To me, Yale should look like America."

Labeling diversity as a "convenient pretense" for anti-Asian discrimination in a September 2018 press release, the AACE has rejected these arguments from supporters of race-conscious admissions. Manga Anantatmula, an Indian American member of the AACE Board of Directors, cited a 2007 study in the *American Journal of Education* reporting that 40 percent of Black Ivy League admits were not from the U.S. She additionally argued that many Black international students come from wealthy African families.

Anantatmula believes the diversity cultivated by affirmative action at schools like Harvard and Yale is performative. "[These policies] are definitely not serving the interests of the United States' minority communities," she said. Zhao further argued that university admissions officers should instead aim to create socioeconomic, rather than racial, diversity.

Wang, however, thinks that discounting race in favor of socioeconomic diversity is reductive. "We can't understand socioeconomic diversity without considering race," she said, making reference to gentrification and the historical importance of racially discriminatory practices like redlining.

Khiara Bridges, a law professor at Boston University who also supports race-conscious admissions, went further: diversity alone, she believes, should not be the focus of affirmative action policies. Rather, affirmative action should address concerns about historical discrimination and injustice. "The discourse around affirmative action has been bastardized to the extent that it never makes mention anymore of injustice and [the] attempts to remedy that injustice," she said.

Bridges feels that current dialogues regarding affirmative action are missing a radicalism they once possessed. "Affirmative action is talked about as something that's good for students since they get to hear different viewpoints, that it's good for educational outcomes," she said. "All that might be well and true, but the origins of affirmative action are squarely



in the civil rights movement, in claims for inclusion, claims for racial justice."

Carlson-White agrees, contending that affirmative action is a useful tool for counteracting racialized inequities that have been entrenched in America's institutions for centuries.

"Many students of color are attending incredibly underfunded schools in cities and towns across America," he observed. Students of color face structural disadvantages and a lack of resources, Carlson-White said, making them "appear less smart or less capable in the eyes of the supposedly objective testing system."

MANY OF THE structural problems that affirmative action aims to address originate in primary and secondary schools, and some of its most adamant supporters also advocate for more comprehensive solutions to racial injustice. Wang thinks scrutinizing the prejudices of admissions officers at schools like Harvard and Yale isn't nearly enough to fight racial discrimination. "We also need to be talking about the biases of the guidance counselors and teachers that are writing these recommendation letters," she said. "It's a system that reinforces this idea, not just the individual biases of these admissions officers."

Wang contends that we should direct our criticism toward education policy, noting that white teachers and guidance counselors at large public schools, each with their own implicit biases, often end up writing recommendations for students of color they might not know well.

For Forman, these educational inequities are a product of America's racist history. "Because of all of this history, of educational disparities, of wealth disparities, of Black soldiers not being able to access the benefits of the GI Bill, Black citizens have been at an extraordinary historical disadvantage," he said. "And it's not a disadvantage that you make up for in a generation." He added that many students are at Yale today because of their family's wealth and educational resources, which "Black communities were denied equal access to."

Carlson-White raised the issue of generational privilege, too. Instead of focusing exclusively on race-conscious admissions, he believes those concerned with fair admissions policies should be seeking to dismantle legacy admissions. "These universities could accept a lot more African American *and* Asian students if they accepted less white students grandfathered into the process through legacy admissions," he said.

And, in fact, many members of the AACE would agree. Zhao strongly condemned legacy admissions at Ivy League universities.

"If Harvard and Yale really cared about African American and Hispanic students," Zhao asked, "why aren't they giving these legacy spots to minority students?"

TODAY, PROSPECTS for supporters of race-conscious admissions look grim. With the AACE and SFFA enjoying the Trump administration's support, college admissions consultants and legal experts alike expect a favorable outcome for the two groups.

"They're enjoying a perfect storm right now," Taylor said.

Rein explained that the Trump administration could conclude that Harvard and Yale are violating the Civil Rights Act and threaten to cut off federal funding.

Separately, Rein predicted that if *Students for Fair Admissions v. Harvard* were to reach the Supreme Court, the outcome would likely favor SFFA. In explanation, he noted that conservative Justice Brett Kavanaugh had replaced Justice Anthony Kennedy, who crucially voted to uphold the University of Texas' affirmative action policy in 2016. "Like it or not, the reality is that when these cases get to the Supreme Court, the vote is not going to be the same as it was before," Rein said.

Taylor concurred.

"With the appointment of Justice Kavanaugh, I think affirmative action will be all but over by 2020," he said.

Though affirmative action's future may be dim, its supporters, like Wang, stand by their principles. She reflected on the importance of race-conscious admissions for the country as a whole. "We need these private institutions to protect racial diversity because of all of the stakes that it has for American democracy and understanding the ways race affects structural issues," she said.

Wang concluded, "Asian Americans need to use this moment to understand our position in American society and criticize, from an academic and personal experience standpoint, race relations in the United States."

"If Harvard and Yale really cared about African American and Hispanic students, why aren't they giving these legacy spots to minority students?"

on-line pre-view

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Laboratories of Democracy: Transformational Festivals as Activist Spaces

Transformational music festivals, such as Beloved, Lightning in a Bottle, Symbiosis Gathering, and Lucidity, are different from other concert venues; they provide spaces for activism and experimentation with radical new ideas. They are also not immune from controversy—festivals have been criticized about their lack of participant diversity, a large environmental impact, and the high cost of attendance. Emily Xu '21 discusses the allure, impact, and potential of transformational festivals.

Xi Dada?: Chinese Arbitrary Detention under Xi Jinping

On July 2, 2018, Fan Bingbing, the highest-paid actor in China in 2017, posted on social media about a visit to a children's hospital in Tibet. That same day, her account went dead. Rumors circulated, as nobody knew what exactly happened to Fan. As strong as China has become under Xi Jinping's rule, there is a dark side to his leadership. Gabriel Klapholz '22 investigates mysterious disappearances and arbitrary detentions in China.

A Whiff of Change: Improving the Senior A Cappella Experience at Yale

The Whiffenpoofs, established in 1909, are Yale's oldest a capella group—and were all male until 2018. In 1981, an all-female group named Whim'n Rhythm was founded to balance the decades-old tradition of the Whiffenpoofs and to give women a greater opportunity to participate in senior a cappella. Nicola Haubold '19 dissects the historic and present inequities between the two groups and their efforts to bridge the gap.

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